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India warns WTO members against using ‘transparency’ for retaliation

Developing nations agree in principle that transparency is important, but have serious reservations about how the US wants to implement it

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has cautioned WTO members against weaponising “transparency” to justify trade retaliation or challenge legitimate domestic policies, saying it should be backed by sustained capacity-building support to ensure that all countries meet obligations fairly and effectively.

“Transparency” is a key component of the technical barriers to trade agreement of the World Trade Organisation (WTO). Under this, member nations have to regularly and clearly share information about their trade policies, subsidies, and regulatory measures.

The US has been pushing for stricter rules on mandatory disclosures as part of the WTO reform proposal. It alleges that many countries do not timely notify subsidies, tariffs, or policy changes to the WTO.

Developing member nations of the WTO agree in principle that transparency is important, but have serious reservations about how the US wants to implement it. These emerging economies oppose penalties for failure to notify information, arguing that many



‘Transparency’ is a key component of the technical barriers to trade agreement of the WTO. Under this, member nations have to regularly and clearly share information about their trade policies, subsidies, and regulatory measures

countries lack capacity.

“India has cautioned WTO members against weaponising transparency to justify trade retaliation or challenge legitimate domestic policies, saying it must be backed by sustained capacity-building support to ensure all members, especially developing countries, can meet

obligations fairly and effectively,” the commerce ministry said in a statement.

The issue was flagged on March 27 by Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal in a session on ‘level playing field issues’ of the 14th ministerial conference (MC14), which is underway in Yaounde, Cam-

Highlights

- » The emerging economies oppose penalties for failure to notify information, arguing that many countries lack capacity
- » The US alleges that many countries do not timely notify subsidies, tariffs, or policy changes to the World Trade Organisation
- » India has also stressed on the importance of all members to have a fair opportunity to build productive capacity, create employment, and participate meaningfully in global trade

enate meaningfully in global trade.

In a separate session, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said the country supports a time-bound restart of reform efforts with milestones, but said that it should be based on a more robust evidentiary analysis and through engagement with submissions and Ministerial Decisions.

“India unequivocally called for eschewing cherry-picking issues and proliferating pre-conceived and prejudged positions,” it said.

He also cautioned against plurilateral agreements, saying they divide the multilateral trading system.

Agrawal called for the consensus process to be premised on the principles of openness, transparency, inclusivity, participative and member-driven, it added.

On the sidelines of the conference, Goyal held a bilateral meeting with his Canadian counterpart, Maninder Sidhu and took stock of the progress of negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement. He also met Oman’s Secretary of State to the Minister of Industry and Trade, Omar Hejira.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Saturday said consensus-based decision-making, most favoured nation (MFN) rule-based trade, and special and differential treatment in the WTO are key to ensuring balance in global trade.

He also emphasised the need to uphold the World Trade Organisation’s (WTO) foundational principles.

The minister stated this during his meeting with WTO Reform Minister-Facilitators Espen Barth Eide, Norway’s Minister of Foreign Affairs and Chris Bryant, UK Minister of State for Trade Policy, on the margins of the ongoing 14th ministerial conference of the WTO at Yaounde in Cameroon.

“Reiterated India’s full support for a reformed, relevant, and effective WTO. Emphasised the need to uphold the organisation’s foundational principles, particularly consensus-based decision-making, MFN rule-based trade, and Special and Differential Treatment, which are essential to ensuring equity and balance in global trade,” Goyal said in a social media post.

The four-day ministerial conference (MC) will end on March 29. The MC is the highest decision-making body, which meets once every two years.

WTO is a 166-member



Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

Geneva-based body which deals with global trade related issues. It also adjudicates disputes between the member countries. India is a member since 1995.

WTO reform is a key agenda being pushed by developed countries, particularly the US. India is supporting this but has stated that the core principle of the organisation should not be diluted.

The WTO is run by its member governments. All major decisions are made by the membership as a whole, either by ministers (who meet at least once every two years) or by their ambassadors or delegates (who meet regularly in Geneva). Decisions are normally taken by consensus.

The US is pushing for World reforms and has raised issues with regard to consensus-based decision making process. It has argued that this process slows down decision making. However, developing economies, including India, is

of the view that it ensures equal voices to all members.

The most favoured nation (MFN) principle states that all member countries should be treated equally. Under the WTO agreements, member countries cannot normally discriminate between their trading partners. If a nation extends lower import duty benefits to one of its trading partners, that rate has to be granted to others also. Exceptions are allowed only under free trade agreement.

Special and differential treatment (S&DT) allows developing and poor (less developed) countries to enjoy certain benefits, including taking longer time for implementing agreements and binding commitments, and measures to increase trading opportunities for them.

Currently, any WTO member can designate itself as a developing country and avail these benefits. Some developed nations have stated that self-declaration puts the WTO on a path to failed negotiations and it is also a path to institutional irrelevance.

As part of the proposed WTO reforms, developed countries are saying that developing countries are bypassing rules in the name of self-proclaimed development status in the WTO.

On the other hand, developing nations, including India, are demandeurs for special and differential treatment.

PESB names Ashok Panda for post of SAIL CMD

NEW DELHI: Government head-hunter PESB has recommended Ashok Kumar Panda, Director (Finance) of SAIL, for the top post at India’s largest public-sector steel-making entity.

Panda was among the 10 shortlisted candidates interviewed for the post of Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) at Steel Authority of India Ltd (SAIL).

The top post will fall vacant after the term of the present CMD, Amarendu Prakash, ends on April 2, 2026. Prakash assumed the charge of SAIL Chairman on May 31, 2023.

In a notification dated March 28, the Public Enterprises Selection Board (PESB) said it has recommended Ashok Kumar Panda for the post of CMD SAIL. Panda currently holds the post of Director, Finance, in the company.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC), headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, is the final authority approving appointments to top-level positions at central PSUs.

Panda is a seasoned finance professional with over three decades of experience in accounting, costing & budgeting, Annual Business Planning, Project Commercial Activities, Treasury Operations, superannuation trusts, Taxation and Strategic Management.

He started his career with SAIL as a Management Trainee after completing his B.E. in Electrical Engineering. PFI

Centre pushes for faster expansion of PNG, targets 50 lakh new connections

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: A key meeting on expanding Piped Natural Gas (PNG) services in urban areas took place at Vigyan Bhavan on Saturday. It brought together important groups from the Centre, States, and industry to speed up access to clean energy and ensure steady essential services.

The meeting included Union Ministers, senior officials, state representatives, municipal commissioners, and leaders from major public sector companies like GAIL and Indian Oil Corporation, as well as City Gas Distribution (CGD) entities.

Union Housing and Affairs Minister Manohar Lal Khattar called for a focused approach to expanding PNG networks. He pointed out that cities drive economic growth. He discussed priorities such



Union Housing and Urban Affairs Minister Manohar Lal Khattar

as streamlined approvals, integrating gas infrastructure into urban planning, and improving last-mile connectivity. He also set a bold target of adding 50 lakh new PNG connections.

Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri highlighted the need to strengthen PNG infrastructure due to changing global energy trends.

He urged states to encourage its use, especially in areas with existing networks.

Consumer Affairs Minister Pralhad Joshi stressed the importance of ensuring continuous essential supplies and stopping black marketing. He supported a gradual transition from LPG to PNG, especially in public institutions.

Officials remarked that PNG has benefits like safety, cost-effectiveness, and environmental sustainability. However, issues such as delays in municipal permissions, Right of Way (RoW) approvals, and high restoration charges still block expansion.

States and urban local bodies agreed to simplify approval processes, reduce charges, and appoint nodal officers for better coordination.

A follow-up breakout session addressed specific city issues, with stakeholders committing to time-bound action plans and ongoing monitoring.

PM E-DRIVE scheme: Govt sets new deadlines for e-scooters & e-rickshaws

NEW DELHI: The government has revised the PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE) Scheme to set new deadlines and unit caps for e-scooters and e-rickshaws.

The Centre has revised the guidelines under the Rs 10,900 crore PM E-DRIVE scheme, whereby electric two-wheelers registered till July 31, 2026 and electric three-wheelers (e-rickshaws & e-carts) shall be eligible for incentives.

The maximum ex-factory price to avail an incentive is capped at Rs 1.5 lakh for electric two-wheelers and Rs 2.5 lakh for electric three-wheelers. The

total payout under the Scheme shall be limited to the scheme outlay of Rs 10,900 crore.

“In case the funds for the Scheme or its relevant sub-components are exhausted prior to the terminal date of the Scheme, i.e. March 31, 2028, then the Scheme or its relevant sub-components will be closed accordingly, i.e. no further claims will be entertained,” the Heavy Industries Ministry said.

However, the terminal date for registered electric two-wheelers shall be July 31, 2026, and the terminal date for registered electric three-wheelers (e-rickshaws & e-carts) shall be March 31, 2028, the notification added. PFI

Adani Defence & Aerospace delivers 1st batch of 2,000 ‘Prahar’ light machine guns to Army

GWALIOR: In a boost to the Indian Army’s firepower, a defence major on Saturday delivered the first batch of 2,000 ‘Prahar’, light machine guns (LMGs), manufactured under the ‘Make in India’ initiative. The 7.62 mm-calibre weapon has been manufactured by Adani Defence & Aerospace at its Small Arms Complex located on the outskirts of Gwalior.

A ceremony was held on its premises on Saturday to hand over the LMGs to the Army, which was attended by A Anbarasu, DG Acquisition, Ministry of Defence, Ashish Rajvanshi, CEO of Adani Defence and Aerospace, and other senior officials of the private firm.



A Anbarasu, DG Acquisition, Ministry of Defence, Ashish Rajvanshi, CEO of Adani Defence & Aerospace flag off trucks carrying ‘Prahar’ light machine guns (LMGs) at its Small Arms Complex, in Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh on Saturday PFI

Anbarasu later flagged off a series of trucks carrying the first batch of the LMGs meant for the Army. Interacting with

robust macroeconomic fundamentals and sustained policy efforts provide resilience, the evolving situation warrants close monitoring and calibrated policy responses,” it said.

The government’s interventions across energy diversification, agricultural preparedness, inflation conditions, external sector strength, and policy measures support the economy’s ability to absorb near-term disruptions arising from global developments, while ongoing monitoring and calibrated responses remain important

in view of evolving conditions, it said.

While these interventions, along with existing macroeconomic buffers, provide some support, the balance of risks remains tilted to the downside.

In this context, continued vigilance and proactive policy measures will be important to mitigate the impact of evolving global uncertainties, it said.

The report further said that the recent oil price shock presents an upside risk to the inflation trajectory in the medium term, as higher energy costs are gradually transmitted into domestic prices, particularly in fuel-intensive sectors.

While supply disruptions have added to cost pressures, selective price corrections in perishables, amid export-related dislocations, point to localised demand-supply imbalances, it said.

“A sustained elevation in oil and gas prices could lead to broader second-round effects through input cost pass-through across sectors. Nonetheless, the Government remains vigilant, with measures underway to ensure adequate domestic energy availability and mitigate potential inflationary pressures,” it said.

Elevated global crude oil prices also pose risks to the merchandise trade balance, while the outlook for remittances also remains sensitive as the Gulf Cooperation Council economies accounted for about 38 per cent of India’s total remittances in FY24 and host nearly half of India’s migrants worldwide, it said. In an increasingly uncertain global environment, it said, the resilience of the Indian economy will depend on the strengthening of domestic fundamentals. PFI

‘Jag Vasant’ carrying 47K MT LPG arrives Vadinar port

AHMEDABAD: Indian-flagged vessel ‘Jag Vasant’ carrying 47,000 metric tonnes (MT) of LPG arrived at Vadinar port in Gujarat’s Jamnagar after crossing the Strait of Hormuz amid the West Asia crisis, an official said on Saturday.

MT Jag Vasant was anchored at 8.30 pm on Friday, loaded from Mina Al Ahmadi Port, Kuwait, according to a statement from Deendayal Port Authority, of which Vadinar port is a part. It is set for ship-to-ship transfer at anchorage, it added.

“The 230-metre-long vessel is currently transferring 17,600 metric tonnes of LPG to the daughter vessel MT Rose Gas, a process expected to take approximately 15 hours. Following the transfer, the daughter vessel will proceed towards Kandla to discharge further,” a port official said.

Cargo of 20,000 MT on ‘Jag Vasant’, the mother vessel, will be discharged at Mumbai and another around 9,000 MT will later be discharged at Mangaluru, the official added. PFI

‘India signals openness to extend tariff-free deal on e-commerce’

Piyush Goyal had on Thursday cast doubt on US efforts to permanently extend the moratorium – which is set to expire this month

YAOUNDE: India has signalled it may drop its opposition to the extension of a global agreement to not impose tariffs on electronic transmissions such as digital downloads and streaming, two senior diplomats said.

India’s Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal had on Thursday cast doubt on US efforts to permanently extend the moratorium – which is set to expire this month – during a World Trade Organization meeting in Cam-

eroon this week, saying it warranted “careful reconsideration.”

However, India late on Friday night indicated to WTO members it would agree to an extension of two years, two senior diplomatic sources said, in the first sign of an opening in its position, ahead of the WTO meeting on the matter on Saturday. It is unclear, however, if a short-term extension would be satisfactory to the US. The US trade Representative (USTR)

CLOSER LOOK

- » However, India late on Friday night indicated to WTO members it would agree to an extension of two years
- » USTR Jamieson Greer said Washington not interested in a temporary extension to the ban, only a permanent one

Jamieson Greer said on Thursday Washington was not interested in a temporary extension to the ban, only a permanent one, Reuters reported.

Business leaders say an extension is critical to guarantee predictability, fearing duties could be introduced if the agreement lapses. Two senior dip-

lomats said US and Indian positions were still far apart.

A third senior diplomat said that members are trying to forge a middle path of extending the moratorium beyond the next ministerial meeting – between five and 10 years. It was uncertain if the US or India would accept a middle ground, they added.

The extension of the e-commerce moratorium during the WTO meeting in Yaounde is

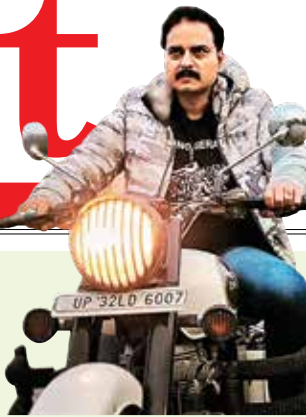
being seen as a key test for the global watchdog’s relevancy, following a year of tariff-fuelled trade turmoil and major disruption to shipping, energy prices and supply chains due to the Middle East conflict.

“I think for some countries it’s actually quite existential to prolong the moratorium for a significant time,” Norwegian Foreign Minister Espen Barth Eide said, adding it would help demonstrate that ministers were

able to deliver something concrete at the meeting in Yaounde.

For nearly three decades the e-commerce moratorium has been continually extended until the next ministerial conference.

The US wants major American tech businesses such as Amazon, Microsoft and Apple to have a stable regulatory environment without the fear and costs of countries introducing duties that could impact cross-border digital trade. AGENCIES



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‘No extra burden on Delhiites’: CM



NATION: Pg 6

PM Modi speaks to Saudi Crown Prince, discusses West Asia situation



FILM: Pg 14

‘Didn’t know that my character was Bade Sahab’

WAR NEARS ONE MONTH

Houthis enter fray, Red Sea on edge

First Houthi strike on Israel foiled | Iran hits Saudi base; US troops hurt, jets hit

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iranian-backed Houthi rebels claimed a missile launch toward Israel early Saturday, their first since the war in the Middle East started. The Israeli military said it intercepted the projectile.

The now month-long war erupted after the United States and Israel attacked Iran, which retaliated with strikes against Israel and neighbouring Gulf Arab states.

The conflict has upended global air travel, disrupted oil exports and caused fuel prices to soar.

Iran’s stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz, a strategic waterway, has exacerbated the economic fallout.

Israel struck Iran’s nuclear facilities hours after threatening to “escalate and expand” its campaign against Tehran on Friday. Iran vowed to retaliate and struck a base in Saudi Arabia, wounding more than a dozen US service members and damaging planes.

Before Saturday’s attack, there appeared to be a breakthrough as Tehran agreed to allow humanitarian aid and agricultural shipments through the strait.

Israeli airstrikes continued Saturday. Associated Press



» SATURDAY’S ASSAULT CALLS INTO QUESTION WHETHER THE HOUTHIS WILL TARGET COMMERCIAL SHIPPING IN THE RED SEA CORRIDOR, AS THEY DID DURING THE ISRAEL-HAMAS WAR

footage showed smoke rising from northeastern Tehran. Iran sent missiles toward Israel with loud booms heard in Jerusalem.

Houthi Brig. Gen. Yahya Saree said on the rebels’ Al-Masirah satellite television station Saturday that the Houthis launched a barrage of ballistic missiles toward what he described as “sensitive Israeli

military sites” in southern Israel. The attack came hours after Saree signalled in a vague statement Friday that the rebels would join the war.

Sirens went off around Israel’s southern city of Beer Sheba and near Israel’s main nuclear research centre as Iran and Hezbollah fired on Israel overnight.

Explosions filled the air in Tel Aviv, where Israel’s Fire

and Rescue Service said it responded to 11 impact sites.

Saturday’s assault calls into question whether the Houthis will target commercial shipping in the Red Sea corridor, as they did during the Israel-Hamas war.

About USD 1 trillion worth of goods passed through the Red Sea annually before the war. The rebels also fired

NEW FRONT

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» Explosions filled the air in Tel Aviv, where Israel’s Fire and Rescue Service said it responded to 11 impact sites

UAE intercept fallout injures five Indians

DUBAI: Five Indians were injured in the UAE by the fall of debris in the vicinity of the Khalifa Economic Zones Abu Dhabi (KEZAD) following interception of a ballistic missile by the country’s air defence system, local media reported on Saturday.

The Abu Dhabi Media Office in a social media post said the authorities confirmed that the incident resulted in injuries to five individuals of Indian nationality, ranging from moderate to minor.

“The competent authorities urge the public to obtain information from official sources only, and to avoid circulating rumours or unverified information,” it said.

Earlier, it reported that the authorities were responding to two fire incidents in

Continued on P6

Jewar takes wing

PM Modi flags ethanol boost amid global energy shocks



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya, Governor Anandiben Patel, and others, during inauguration of the Noida International Airport, in Jewar, Gautam Buddha Nagar district, Uttar Pradesh

PTI

BISWAJEET BANERJEE/ NARESH BISWANI

JEWAR: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday inaugurated the Phase 1 of the much-awaited Noida International Airport in UP’s Jewar.

PM Modi called the airport a symbol of “India’s new spirit” and stressed on its potential to drive development in Uttar Pradesh. The inauguration of the new airport marks the fulfilment of a nearly 25-year-old aspiration to connect Noida to global air routes. The airport has been developed with an investment of around Rs 11,200 crore in its first phase.

As the war rages in West Asia, PM Modi stressed on how India’s ethanol blending initiative has helped the country amid the crisis affecting global energy markets.

Addressing a large gathering, Modi linked India’s ethanol blending programme to energy security amid the ongoing global turmoil while positioning the project as part of a broader push towards self-reliance and infrastructure-led growth. He also framed the airport as a symbol of collective ownership and national aspiration.

The Prime Minister said, “You are all seeing how wor-

SKY SURGE

» The airport has been developed with an investment of around Rs 11,200 crore in its first phase

» Commercial flight operations are expected to commence from April

» Built over 3,300 acres, the first phase of the airport is nearing completion with one terminal and a runway ready for operations

» In its initial phase, it is expected to handle nearly 30 million passengers annually, significantly reducing the load on IGI Airport in the national Capital

THE AIRPORT WAS FINALLY OPENED AFTER MULTIPLE DELAYS

ried the whole world is today... In West Asia, there has been a war going on for a month.” Pointing to disruptions in supplies of petrol, diesel, gas and coal, he added that India has relied on domestic resilience to navigate the crisis.

He emphasised that the airport will serve as a catalyst for

Continued on P6

ALL 160 SAFE

Mid-air scare: IndiGo lands on one engine in Capital

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: A Delhi-bound IndiGo flight from Visakhapatnam, carrying 160 passengers on board, made an emergency landing at Delhi’s Indira Gandhi International Airport on Saturday due to an engine failure, according to sources.

“Full emergency was declared at Indira Gandhi International Airport at 10.39 for IndiGo Visakhapatnam-Delhi flight 6E 579 due to one engine failure,” a source said. There were 160 passengers on board the Boeing 737 aircraft, the source said.

The flight landed at 10.59 am as per flight tracking website flightradar24.com.

Meanwhile, IndiGo, in a statement, said: “A technical snag was detected shortly before landing on IndiGo flight 6E 579 operating from Visakhapatnam to Delhi on 28 March 2026.”

“As a precautionary step and in accordance with the standard operating procedure, the pilots requested for priority landing and the aircraft arrived safely at Indira Gandhi International Airport, Delhi.

All relevant authorities were promptly informed and the aircraft is undergoing necessary checks and maintenance,” an IndiGo Spokesperson said.

International Film Festival of Delhi providing national platform for talent
Delhi Minister Kapil Mishra

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Gurugram: 3 lives, one reckless Thar

Two boys, granddad killed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: A speeding Thar mowed down two boys and their grandfather in Khod village of Pataudi, police said on Saturday.

The police have arrested the accused driver and taken the SUV into custody after registering an FIR, they said.

Zayed Khan and Ishant, aged eight and 10, died on the spot, while their maternal grandfather, 60-year-old Subhash, succumbed in a hospital, they said.

The deceased hailed from Milkpur village in Bhiwadi, Rajasthan. According to the police, Subhash had come to Lokra Road near Khod village to visit his brothers with his two grandsons.

Around 11 pm on Friday, when he was returning home with the two boys, a Mahindra Thar allegedly struck them from behind, throwing them several feet away from the point of impact, the police said.

After receiving information, the police from Pataudi police station took the three bodies into custody and sent them to the mortuary.

After the accident, the driver of the SUV (Thar) fled after leaving his vehicle on spot. Continued on P6

SPEED KILLS

» The police have arrested the accused driver and taken the SUV into custody after registering an FIR

» After receiving information, the police from Pataudi police station took the three bodies into custody and sent them to the mortuary

» After the accident, the driver of the SUV (Thar) fled after leaving his vehicle on spot

Gen Z protest crackdown: Nepal ex-PM held

SHIRISH B PRADHAN

KATHMANDU: Nepal’s former Prime Minister K P Sharma Oli was arrested on Saturday, a day after the newly formed government of Balendra Shah implemented the probe commission report on the Gen Z protest that rocked the nation last year.

Oli, also CPN-UML chair, was arrested at the Gundu area of Bhaktapur district, 12 km east of Kathmandu, early Saturday morning, according to the police.



Former Home Minister and Nepali Congress leader Ramesh Lekhak has also been arrested from his residence at Katunje of Suryabinayak Municipality in

Former Home Minister and Nepali Congress leader Ramesh Lekhak has also been arrested from his residence

Bhaktapur district, police added. Both Oli and Lekhak have been arrested on charges of their involvement in suppressing the Gen Z movement of September 8

and 9 last year, in which 76 people, including around two dozen youths, were killed.

The probe commission formed to investigate the incident surrounding the Gen Z movement has recommended legal action against Oli and Lekhak, among others, under criminal offence.

Nepal’s newly formed government, led by Balendra Shah, in its first cabinet meeting on Friday, decided to immediately implement the recommendations made by the probe commission. Continued on P6

Just two, no Musk: India

Calls it strictly bilateral, refutes report

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India on Saturday rejected a media report that said billionaire Elon Musk joined a phone conversation between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump earlier this week.

External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said Tuesday’s conversation was between the two leaders only. The New York Times, quoting unnamed US officials, reported that Musk participated in the call between Trump and Modi, adding it was an “unusual appearance” by a private citizen on a call between two heads of state.

“We have seen the story. The telephone conversation on March 24



was between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Donald Trump only,” Jaiswal said.

“As has been stated earlier, it provided the opportunity for exchange of views on the situation in West Asia,” he said.

In its report, the New York Times said it is “unclear” why Musk was on the call or whether he spoke.

Continued on P6

WINNING START



Virat Kohli (69) and Devdutt Padikkal (61) power RCB to six-wicket win over SRH

See P8

INDIA OUTPACES GLOBAL DECLINE

Maternal deaths nosedive 86% since 1990

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The maternal mortality ratio in India has come down by 86 per cent since 1990, which is nearly double that of the global average of 48 per cent, the Health Ministry said Saturday.

As per the latest Sample Registration System (SRS) 2021-23, the maternal mortality ratio (MMR) of the country stands at 88 per lakh live births, ministry sources said.

They were reacting to a study published in The Lancet Obstetrics, Gynaecology, and Women’s Health journal that estimated India’s maternal deaths in 2023 to be 24,700, translating to a maternal mortality ratio of 116 per one lakh livebirths -- a nearly 80 per cent reduction since 1990, when

the ratio was 508 per one lakh livebirths.

Researchers, led by those from the Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation (IHME) at the University of Washington, US and global collaborators, noted that maternal deaths have declined over the past three decades, yet progress has slowed in recent years and remains uneven across countries.

The Global Burden of Disease (GBD) 2023 research provides the most up-to-date global assessment of maternal mortality trends across 204 countries and territories through 2023, they said.

The Health Ministry said in a statement that the figure of 88 per one lakh live births demonstrates progress in ensuring safe preg-

BIG DROP

» As per the latest Sample Registration System (SRS) 2021-23, the maternal mortality ratio (MMR) of the country stands at 88 per lakh live births

» The Health Ministry said in a statement that the figure of 88 per one lakh live births demonstrates progress in ensuring safe pregnancies and childbirth

nancies and childbirth.

“Our progress in maternal health is globally recognised and



» They were reacting to a study published in The Lancet Obstetrics, Gynaecology, and Women’s Health journal that estimated India’s maternal deaths in 2023 to be 24,700, translating to a maternal mortality ratio of 116 per one lakh livebirths

according to the latest United Nations Maternal Mortality Estimation Inter-Agency Group

(UN-MMEIG) Report, India has achieved an 86 per cent reduction in MMR since 1990, which far exceeds the global average of 48 per cent. This accomplishment underscores India’s commitment to meeting Sustainable Development Goals benchmark of reducing MMR below 70 by 2030,” the statement said.

The world saw a total of 2.4 lakh maternal deaths in 2023, which equates to a global maternal mortality ratio of 190.5 maternal deaths per one lakh livebirths -- a decline by more than one-third from 321 maternal deaths per one lakh livebirths in 1990, the researchers estimated.

Improved access to antenatal care, safe delivery services, emergency obstetric

Continued on P6

ONE MONTH INTO WAR

Iranian people wrestle with lost livelihoods, bombs, uncertainties

CAIRO: Iranians were already reeling from a shattered economy and mass killing of protesters when the first US-Israel bombs slammed into Tehran a month ago.

Now they are struggling to get by through a war with no end in sight, wrestling with lost livelihoods, damage to homes and the stress of explosions. Many wonder where it is leading — to the destruction of their homeland, the chaotic fall of the theocracy or its survival, wounded but more extreme.

“I think we’ve experienced everything bad possible, from the terrible atmosphere of January, the killings and arrests, to the war,” said a 26-year-old designer in Tehran.

Daily explosions, near and far and unpredictable, shake and damage homes. Businesses are struggling. An unprecedented internet blackout since January has largely cut people off from the outside world and made communication within Iran more difficult.

The trauma of war comes on top of the shock from Janu-



A man walks at a damaged auto service centre in Tehran on Saturday AP

ary, when hundreds of thousands across Iran marched in the biggest protests against the theocracy in decades — only to be met by security forces opening fire, killing thousands. Tens of thousands were detained, and arrests have continued.

The designer, who with a partner runs a factory making leather fashion products, said her business was on the verge of closing.

“When the economy gets bad, nonessential goods are the first thing to be removed from the shopping cart,” she said.

Much of her sales are online, and the internet blackout practically reduced “the small sales to zero.” Since the January protests, she has had to live off her meagre savings, and the violence of the crackdown upset her so much she has not been able to return to work.

When the war began on February 28, she moved to her parents’ house. A few days later, the blast from a nearby strike damaged her apartment that she had just left. Like most Iranians, she doesn’t have home insurance, so she will have to

INSIGHT

- » Daily explosions, near and far and unpredictable, shake and damage homes
- » Businesses are struggling
- » An unprecedented internet blackout since January has largely cut people off from the outside world

pay for repairs herself.

She only leaves her parents’ house to buy necessities.

Trying to track strikes The terrifying cadence of airstrikes shapes daily life in Tehran. An engineer living in Tehran tries to find a pattern in strikes — are certain times safer? Recent nights saw explosions light up the skies. One evening, a blast shook his home as he had guests over. They climbed up on the roof and tried in vain to figure out where it hit. “We didn’t see any visible fire,” he said. He thinks the

strikes are less frequent now, or maybe “our perception of it has changed,” as everyone gets used to bombings.

He feels anxious when family or friends go out on the streets, and struggles to sleep. He had a job offer before the war but does not know if it is still there. Soon, he says, many will struggle with rent and bills.

Government workers, who make up a large part of the workforce, are still getting salaries. But private businesses are struggling to pay employees as they close for days on end or reduce hours.

Many Iranians have fled to the north, which has been relatively unscathed. One of the main cities, Rasht, has been packed with Iranians who fled from Tehran and elsewhere, straining local resources.

A doctor at a pediatric hospital said the number of patients has nearly doubled. Medicines are running out, he said, and patients now are asked to buy some basic supplies, including antibiotics or IV fluids, from market. AGENCIES

Russian drone attacks kill five in Ukraine, say officials

Zelenskyy to discuss drone defence during UAE visit

KYIV: Russia launched over 270 drones at Ukraine overnight, killing at least five people, Ukrainian authorities reported on Saturday.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy, meanwhile, made an unannounced visit to the UAE as Kyiv seeks to use its drone defence expertise to help Arab states blunt Iran’s attacks.

Two people were killed and at least 11 more were injured in a nighttime Russian drone strike on Odesa, according to the head of the region, Serhii Lysak. According to his Telegram posts, the attack damaged a maternity hospital and private houses in the major Black Sea port city.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said the “massive” strike involved more than 60 drones. “Last night, the Russians launched a massive strike on Odesa. There was no military purpose whatsoever — this was pure terror against ordinary civilian life,” he said Saturday on X.

He added that port and “critical” infrastructure was also damaged, as well as



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

business premises. Two men died and two more were injured early on Saturday in Kryvyi Rih, Zelenskyy’s hometown in central Ukraine, after a Russian drone hit an industrial facility, regional head Oleksandr Gandzha said in a Telegram update. He did not specify what the industrial building was.

One person was killed overnight in the Poltava region, also in central Ukraine, as Russia struck unspecified industrial sites there, regional authorities reported on Saturday.

According to Ukraine’s Air Force, Russia launched 273 drones at Ukraine during the night, 252 of which were downed or electroni-

According to Ukraine’s Air Force, Russia launched 273 drones during the night, 252 of which were downed or electronically jammed

cally jammed. Meanwhile, Emirati state media reported on a meeting between the Ukraine President and his Emirati counterpart Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, to discuss regional security amid the Iran war.

“For Ukraine, this is also a matter of principle: terror must not prevail anywhere in the world. Protection must be sufficient everywhere,” Zelenskyy commented on X following his meeting with the Emirati leader.

He added they had discussed “the security situation in the Emirates, Iranian strikes, and the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, which directly affects the global oil market.” AGENCIES

Nepal: Ex-PM Oli’s arrest draws criticism from political parties

KATHMANDU: Nepalese political parties on Saturday criticised the newly formed Balendra Shah government over the arrest of former Prime Minister K P Sharma Oli for the 2025 Gen Z protest crackdown.

Oli and former Home Minister Ramesh Lekhak have been arrested on charges of their involvement in suppressing the Gen Z movement of September 8 and 9 last year, in which 76 people, including around two dozen youths, were killed.

The Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist) secretary, Mahesh Basnet, called the arrest of party chair Oli a “political revenge” and said that the Balendra Shah-led government is displaying prejudice.

Hours after Oli’s arrest, CPN (UML) called an emergency Central Secretariat meeting to decide the party’s next course of action.

The secretariat held a meeting to clarify the party’s position and decide on the program of the upcoming struggle following the vindictive arrest of Chairman KP Sharma Oli, Basnet said in one of the several posts on social media.

In the meeting, the party demanded the immediate

Oli was arrested on charges of involvement in suppressing 2025 Gen Z protest

release of KP Sharma Oli, it said. CPN (UML) has also decided to hand over protest letters to the Chief District Officers of all 77 districts across Nepal on Sunday.

The party said it will launch a political and legal battle against the arrest in collaboration with civil society members and the general public.

Senior Nepali Congress leader and House of Representatives member, Arjun Narsingha KC, said that the investigation of any incident should be done in a neutral and transparent manner, adding that due procedures should be followed.

He called for an investigation into the events of the attack on many government offices, including the Supreme Court and the Government Secretariat Singhdurbar, during the Gen Z protest. He termed the investigation into the killings during the Gen Z protests last year in September as “insufficient.” AGENCIES

Iran war: German chancellor slams Trump’s approach

BERLIN: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz has sharply criticised US President Donald Trump for his course of action in the Iran conflict, the German Press Agency reported.

“What Trump is doing right now is not de-escalation and an attempt to reach a peaceful solution, but a massive escalation with an uncertain outcome,” Merz said late Friday at an event in Frankfurt.

“These are escalations that are threatening,” he added. “Not only for those directly affected, but for all of us.”

Merz also expressed doubt that the current leadership in Iran can be overthrown by the war.

“Is regime change really the goal?” he said. “If that is the goal, I don’t think they will achieve it. That has usually gone wrong.” AGENCIES

Talks on West Asia: Saudi, Egypt, Turkiye FMs set to visit Pakistan

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan is set to host the foreign ministers of Saudi Arabia, Egypt and Turkiye for discussions on a wide-range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in West Asia amid the war in Iran, the Foreign Office said on Saturday.

At the invitation of Pakistan’s Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, Saudi Arabia Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, Turkiye Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan and Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty, will visit Islamabad on Sunday and Monday, the Foreign Office said.

During the visit, the foreign ministers will hold “in-depth discussions on a range of issues, including efforts to de-escalate tensions in the region”, it added.

The visiting leaders will also meet Prime Minister Shehbaz

‘The visit, at the Pak Deputy PM’s invitation is slated for March 29-30’

Sharif, the Foreign Office said.

It added that Pakistan “highly values its relations with the brotherly countries of Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, and Egypt, and the visit will provide an opportunity to further strengthen Pakistan’s cooperation and coordination with these countries”.

Geo News reported that the meeting was earlier scheduled to be held in Turkiye but due to Dar’s engagement, he requested the leaders to come to Islamabad. “The meeting was scheduled to be held in Turkiye but due to my engagement, I requested my brothers to instead meet in Islamabad

tomorrow (Sunday),” Dar was quoted as saying.

The deputy prime minister said that Pakistan is working with “honesty and sincerity” to resolve ongoing disputes.

Dar said that talks with Iran are continuing, but due to the sensitive nature of the negotiations, officials are refraining from making public statements.

Pakistan on Thursday said that it was “actively and constructively engaged” with all stakeholders in the region and beyond to peacefully end the Iran war. However, Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi did not categorically confirm any chances of face to face talks in Islamabad over the coming weekend.

The spokesperson said that Pakistan has “remained actively and constructively engaged with relevant regional stakeholders.” AGENCIES

Minnesota serves as ‘flagship’ for nationwide protests against Trump

MINNESOTA: Organisers of “No Kings” rallies across the US are predicting that the protests against the actions of President Donald Trump and his administration could add up to one of the largest demonstrations in US history, with Minnesota taking centre stage.

More than 3,100 events have been registered in all 50 states, with more than nine million people expected to participate. The protests began with a

gathering in Paris, France, on Saturday morning. Several hundred people, mostly Americans living in France, along with French labour unions and human rights organisations gathered at Bastille with anti-Trump signs that read “War for profit, our troops are not for sale” and “When injustice becomes law, resistance becomes duty.”

“I protest all of Trump’s illegal, immoral, reckless, and feck-



less, endless wars,” Ada Shen, the Paris No Kings organiser,

Syria: Sectarian attacks rock Christian town

SUQAYLABIYAH: An argument between two men in a Christian town in central Syria led to sectarian attacks that caused widespread damage to homes, shops and cars in a reminder of religious violence that followed the fall of longtime leader Bashar Assad two years ago.

The attacks in the predominantly Christian town of Suqaylabiyah in Hama province are the latest to target members of Syria’s Christian minority, many of whom have left the country since the conflict began 15 years ago, leaving half a million people dead and the population deeply divided.

There was no immediate word on casualties in the attacks that lasted until the early hours of Saturday, during which scores of men on motorcycles from the nearby Sunni town of Qalaat al-Madiq attacked the property of Christians. “We passed through a state of terror, fear, and panic,” said Liyan Dweir, whose clothes shop was riddled with bullets and suffered heavy damage. His children were terrified during the hourslong assault, he said. AGENCIES

Israeli strike in southern Lebanon kills three journalists covering war

BEIRUT: An Israeli airstrike on southern Lebanon on Saturday killed three journalists who were covering the latest Israel-Hezbollah war, their TV stations said.

Hezbollah’s al-Manar TV said that its longtime correspondent Ali Shoeib was killed Saturday in southern Lebanon.

The Israeli military said that it had targeted Shoeib, accusing him of being a Hezbollah intelligence operative without providing evidence.

Meanwhile, Beirut-based pan-Arab Al-Mayadeen TV said reporter Fatima Ftouni was killed in the same airstrike in the southern district of Jezzine along with her brother Mohammed, a video journalist. She had just been on air with a live report from southern Lebanon before the strike.

Top officials in Lebanon condemned the strike, with President Joseph Aoun calling it a “flagrant crime that violates all laws and agreements that protect journalists.” Al-Manar said in a report that an Israeli airstrike targeted journalists, leading to the “martyrdom of the icon of resistance media.” A well-known Lebanese war



A journalist carries burned safety gear, following an Israeli airstrike on a car that killed Hezbollah’s al-Manar TV correspondent Ali Shoeib, Beirut’s based Al-Mayadeen TV reporter Fatima Ftouni and her brother, video journalist Mohammed Ftouni, in Jezzine, Lebanon, Saturday AP

correspondent, Shoeib had covered south Lebanon for Al-Manar for nearly three decades.

The Israeli army claimed that Shoeib was “operating systematically to expose the locations of (Israeli) soldiers operating in southern Lebanon.” The army also accused him of maintaining contact with Hezbollah militants and inciting against Israeli troops and civilians, without elaborating.

Al-Manar TV did not

resistance.

Headlining that observance will be Bruce Springsteen, performing “Streets of Minneapolis”, which he wrote in response to the deaths of Renee Good and Alex Pretti, and in tribute to the thousands of Minnesotans who took to the streets over the winter. Springsteen’s Land of Hope & Dreams American Tour, which has a “No Kings” theme, kicks off Tuesday in Minneapolis. AGENCIES

CONTINENT AT THE PAINFUL END OF RIPPLE EFFECTS Africa is hurting again from global crisis they had ‘no part’ in starting

LAGOS (NIGERIA): Lagos taxi driver Adegbola Isaac went to the gas station twice last weekend. Each time, the price in the Nigerian city had climbed further and hit 1,350 naira (USD 0.99) per litre, a nearly 35 per cent increase since the Iran war started. That’s wiped out most of his daily profit. “It is hitting hard,” Isaac said.

Like many people across the world, Isaac is one of millions across Africa who are reeling from the economic impacts of the faraway conflict in the Middle East, which began Feb. 28 with US-Israeli strikes on Iran.

For many Africans, the fuel price hike because of the Strait of Hormuz being largely closed off worsens the hardships they already struggle with in some of the world’s poorest households.

The latest shock also isn’t isolated. Africa is hurting again from another global crisis it had no part in starting.

From the COVID-19 pandemic to the war in Ukraine and now the Middle East con-



A fuel station in Harare on March 5, 2026 AP

flict, the world’s fastest-growing continent — with a population rivalling China and India — is at the painful end of ripple effects that include a global scramble for critical resources like fuel and fertiliser.

With the majority of African countries being net importers of refined oil products, the impact has been swift, leading to rising retail fuel prices in Africa and associated increases in the costs of most goods and services. Experts say African countries are critically integrated into global economies

and are exposed to global shocks because of their dependence on major economies.

The United Nations on Friday said it is pursuing a way to allow fertiliser to resume safe transit through the Strait of Hormuz, hoping it would build confidence in wider diplomatic efforts around the Iran war.

According to a 2025 report by the UN Trade and Development, or UNCTAD, which describes Africa as “the epicentre of overlapping global crises,” more than half of the continent’s imports and exports

KEY POINTS

- » With the majority of African countries being net importers of refined oil products, the impact has been swift
- » This led to rising retail fuel prices in Africa and associated increases in the costs of most goods and services

are with five non-African countries.

All of Kenya’s fuel comes from the Middle East, particularly from the United Arab Emirates, with its fuel retailers saying 20 per cent of the country’s outlets are already affected. Uganda’s fuel stock was initially projected to last a few weeks.

South Africa sources a significant amount of its fuel from Saudi Arabia. Nigeria, Africa’s largest oil producer, lacks local refinery capacity and relies on importing refined crude products from Europe. AGENCIES

‘No extra burden on Delhiites’: CM Gupta promises relief

‘Prepared to provide continuous convenience’



Rekha Gupta met L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu, at Lok Niwas, on Saturday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi government is working in coordination with the Centre to ensure that no additional burden emerging from global circumstances falls on residents, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Saturday.

Gupta was part of the high-level meeting of states and Union Territories chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday, where discussions focused on maintaining economic momentum and ensuring uninterrupted access to essential resources amid global challenges.

“With the unbreakable spirit of ‘Team India’, under the guidance of the prime minister, we are fully committed to ensuring that no additional burden of global circumstances falls on common citizens,” Gupta said in an X post in Hindi.

Highlights

- » She said the Centre has taken “effective and far-reaching steps” to strengthen supply chains and these measures are helping India remain resilient despite external uncertainties
- » Gupta was part of the high-level meeting of states and UTs chaired by Prime Minister Modi on Friday

She said the Delhi government, in coordination with the Centre, is fully prepared to provide continuous convenience and maintain smooth arrangements for citizens.

“In the current global scenario, maintaining the country’s economic dynamism and ensuring uninterrupted avail-

ability of essential resources is our shared priority,” Gupta said.

She said the Centre has taken “effective and far-reaching steps” to strengthen supply chains, keeping public interest at the forefront, and these measures are helping India remain resilient despite external uncertainties.

On Friday, Prime Minister Narendra Modi chaired a virtual meeting with chief ministers and lieutenant governors to discuss preparedness amid the “dynamic” global situation arising out of the West Asia conflict.

He said the situation necessitates continuous monitoring and adaptive strategies, and called for constant communication between the Centre and the states, along with timely sharing of information and joint decision-making, so that the responses are swift and well-aligned.

Yellow alert for Sunday; light rain, thunderstorm likely

NEW DELHI: The national capital saw a slight decrease in the minimum temperature and a slight increase in the maximum temperature on a cloudy Saturday.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued a yellow alert for Sunday, predicting a spell of light rain and thunderstorms.

The Safdarjung weather station recorded a minimum temperature of 18.8 degrees Celsius, which is 0.7 degrees above normal and a decrease of 1.8 degrees from the previous day. The maximum temperature was recorded at 33.6 degrees Celsius, one degree above normal and an increase of one degree from Friday.

Other weather stations reported similar trends, with Palam recording a maximum temperature of 32.1 degrees Celsius — 1.3 degrees higher than the day before. Palam’s minimum temperature was 18.5 degrees Celsius on Saturday, which is 1.1 degrees lower than the previous day.

While no rain was recorded on Saturday morning, IMD officials noted that cloudy skies persisted in parts of the city throughout the day. AGENCIES

MCD passes key proposals amid LPG shortage row

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The General House meeting of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) witnessed the passage of several public welfare proposals even as proceedings were disrupted by protests from councillors of the Aam Aadmi Party over an alleged shortage of LPG cylinders.

Mayor Sardar Raja Iqbal Singh said that multiple decisions aimed at improving civic infrastructure and public services were approved after deliberations. He maintained that the Corporation remained committed to addressing key issues concerning citizens and ensuring better service delivery.

During the meeting, Leader of the House Praveesh Wahi presented a vote of thanks marking 8,933 days of public service by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, including his tenure as Chief Minister of Gujarat and as Prime Minister. The Mayor described the Prime Minister’s long tenure as reflective of administrative experience and sustained public trust.

The Mayor also wel-

comed the allocation of Rs 11,412 crore to the MCD in the Delhi government’s Budget presented by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, terming it a significant boost for strengthening civic infrastructure, enhancing public services, and supporting environmental initiatives.

However, AAP councillors staged protests inside and outside the House, raising concerns over the reported shortage of LPG cylinders. Terming the issue a matter of public urgency, councillors demanded an immediate discussion, with some entering the House carrying placards and raising slogans.

According to the Mayor, the disruptions were an attempt to divert attention from the scheduled agenda and hinder discussions on civic matters.

Delhi kitchens are feeling the heat

Eattries Juggle limited gas supply and mounting expenses

NEW DELHI: Small eateries, long the backbone of the bustling food streets of the national capital, are losing their spark amid the Iran war. Pushed by dwindling LPG supply and soaring black-market prices, many are being forced to reshape menus, reduce staff, and return to cooking on coal and wood.

For Neeraj Chawla, who has been running Vaishno Rasoi in Rajouri Garden for the past year after stepping away from a joint family setup, the struggle is both financial and

In Short

- » Amid the West Asia crisis, the government has revised the priority order for allocating domestically produced natural gas
- » Pankaj Dawar at KK Da Dhaba has turned to coal and slashed fried items from the menu

personal. Shutting shop would make

sense, he confides, but it is the fear of “beizatti” (shame) that keeps his stoves -- now largely running on coal and wood -- alight, even as hope begins to flicker. “Beizatti nahi ho ke band karke baith gaya hai, isiliye chala raha hoon (I keep it running to avoid the shame of shutting down),” Chawla said.

With daily sales, which once hovered around Rs 12,000 on a good day, slipping further as coal and wood double cooking time and reduce efficiency, Chawla has already had to lay off two staff members.

DISPUTE OVER FOOD ARRANGEMENTS; ALL ACCUSED HELD

Wedding turns tragic as minor stabbed to death

NEW DELHI: Five people, including four minors, have been apprehended for allegedly killing a 17-year-old boy and injuring another when the duo tried to pacify two groups quarrelling at a wedding over food arrangements in outer Delhi’s Rani Bagh area, police said on Saturday.

The incident took place around 11.15 pm on Friday, they said. The deceased was identified as Nikhil Yadav, a bike mechanic, while the injured, Sunny, is undergoing treatment and is stated to be stable. Both were residents of Rohini.

According to the police, an argument broke out between two groups over food arrangements at a wedding function, which quickly escalated into violence.

Eyewitnesses told the police that Nikhil and Sunny tried to

27-year-old crushed by JCB

NEW DELHI: A 27-year-old man was killed after allegedly being run over by a JCB machine in northwest Delhi’s Shakurpur area on Saturday morning, police said.

The incident occurred around 10 am near a graveyard in Shakurpur, following which the police team rushed to the spot, they said. The victim, Md Hussain, a resident of Delhi’s Shakurpur, succumbed to his injuries, the police said.

The JCB’s driver, Ashish (23), a native of Uttar Pradesh’s Azamgarh district, was apprehended by locals at the scene and handed over to the police.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the accused was driving the JCB towards Beriwalla Bagh in Shakurpur for park levelling work when the accident occurred, the police stated. AGENCIES

intervene and pacify the groups when they were attacked with a knife by another minor.

Both sustained serious injuries and were rushed to a nearby hospital, where Nikhil was declared “brought dead”, police said.

Nikhil’s family claimed that

he was attacked after being mistaken for being involved in a fight while trying to intervene in a scuffle among children.

“Last night, my younger brother went to attend a wedding in Rani Bagh. Some children were fighting among themselves, and he went

there to intervene and resolve the matter. There were six or seven boys who were drunk; they misunderstood the situation and thought he was fighting with the children,” Nikhil’s brother, Vikash Yadav, said.

He alleged that the situation escalated when the group began assaulting Nikhil. “One of them took out a knife and stabbed him in the stomach. He died on the spot,” he added.

Friends of the victim said they were informed about the incident over the phone and rushed to the spot. “We were at home. Our friend had gone to someone’s wedding, where he might have had a fight with someone. Someone informed us over the phone that Nikhil had died. Another person, Sunny, was stabbed and admitted to Mahavir Hospital in Rani Bagh,” Nikhil’s friend Rahul said. AGENCIES

NDMC inaugurates ‘Shakti’ art workshop

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Vice-Chairperson of the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), Kuljeet Singh Chahal, inaugurated a five-day women’s art workshop titled “Shakti” at Triveni Kala Sangam.

Organised in collaboration with the institution, the workshop brings together 20 women artists to explore themes of identity, empowerment, and social change through visual art. Noted artist Rameshwar Broota was present at the event.

Chahal said the initiative would become an annual feature of NDMC’s cultural programme. The workshop will conclude with an exhibition on March 31.

Govt allocates Rs 80 cr for SC, ST colonies

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has allocated Rs 80 crore under an improvement scheme for SC/ST colonies, Social Welfare Minister Ravindra Indraj Singh said on Saturday, terming it a step towards strengthening basic civic infrastructure in such areas.

Speaking at a programme held at Maharana Pratap Chowk in Shahbad Dairy, the minister laid foundation stones for street and drainage works and inaugurated the Ready Mix Concrete (RMC) roads.

Singh said the initiative aims to improve living conditions by expanding essential amenities, including construction of pucca roads, strengthening of sewer systems, provision of clean drinking water, better drainage, installation of street lights and other civic facilities.

The minister informed that development works have begun on key stretches, including

Ravindra Indraj Singh laid foundation stones for street and drainage works in Shahbad Dairy

from the JJ Cluster in D-Block, Shahbad Daultapur (Dairy) to Rohini Sector-25, and from Prahlad Vihar Colony Main Road to Shahbad Dairy, which are expected to improve connectivity and accessibility in the area. Singh added that the projects would be completed within the stipulated timeframe while maintaining quality standards.

He said the government remains committed to improving the standard of living across sections of society under its vision of a developed and prosperous Delhi. MPOST

Delhi Police adds cranes, speed cameras to tackle violations

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a push to strengthen traffic enforcement and ease congestion, the Delhi Police on Saturday inducted 76 new cranes into its traffic unit and soft-launched 125 additional over-speeding detection cameras across the national capital.

The fleet of cranes, flagged off by Commissioner of Police Satish Golchha at the Police Headquarters, is aimed at enabling faster removal of illegally parked and stranded vehicles that contribute to traffic bottlenecks in the city.

Additionally, the force expanded its automated enforcement network with 125 new Over-Speeding Violation Detection (OSVD) cameras, taking the total to 250 cameras across more than 140 road stretches.



76 new cranes were inducted into its traffic unit

Equipped with high-resolution imaging and Automated Number Plate Recognition (ANPR), the cameras are integrated with the e-challan system, ensuring quicker and more transparent enforcement.

Senior officers said the initiative is part of a broader shift towards “faceless” and technology-driven policing to curb violations, a major cause of road accidents and fatalities in Delhi.

Meanwhile, a cardiac health awareness camp for police personnel was conducted by iLive Connect, a doctor-led AI healthcare ecosystem, in collaboration with Delhi Police.

The camp, held at the IT Park in Shastri Park here, included heart health check-ups, cardiac disease awareness sessions, and discussions on preventive measures and modern technologies.

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G7 MEET IN FRANCE

Jaishankar flags Global South’s concerns over food, fuel and energy

NEW DELHI: As the world grappled with the cascading fallout of the West Asian conflict, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar flagged the concerns of Global South nations over energy, food, and fuel security, while underlining the urgent need for global governance reforms.

In an address at a G7 foreign ministers’ meeting in France on Thursday, the external affairs minister also spoke about the importance of resilient trade corridors and supply chains against the backdrop of the uncertainties arising from the conflict in West Asia.

While India is not a G7 member, it has been invited as a partner country by France, the current chair of the powerful bloc. Besides India, France invited Saudi Arabia, South Korea and Brazil to attend the G7 foreign ministers’ meeting at Abbaye des-Vaux-de-Cernay.



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar during the G7 Foreign Ministers’ Meeting (G7 FMM) session, in France PTI

On the amrgins of the G7 meeting, Jaishankar held separate conversations with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Saudia Arabia’s Foreign Minister Faisal bin Farhan, German Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul and Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha. It is understood that the West Asia crisis figured prominently in the conversations.

The external affairs minister described his talks with Rubio as “useful”. It was the first meeting between Jaishankar and Rubio since the beginning of the conflict in West Asia on February 28. Jaishankar also met Canadian Foreign Minister Anita Anand, South Korean Foreign Minister Cho Hyun, Italian Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani,

Highlights

- » While India is not a G7 member, it has been invited as a partner country by France
- » It was the first meeting between Jaishankar and Rubio since the beginning of the conflict in West Asia on February 28

Council reforms, streamlining peacekeeping operations, and strengthening humanitarian supply chains.

In a separate session, Jaishankar spoke about the importance of more resilient trade corridors and supply chains against the backdrop of the “uncertainties arising from the conflicts in West Asia”.

He also emphasised the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and said India’s free trade agreements with the European Free Trade Association (EFTA), the UK and the European Union (EU) have enhanced the utility of the corridor.

“Underscored the importance of freedom of navigation for global economic security. As well as the threat of narco - terror linkages. On Critical Minerals, appreciated ongoing steps to expand cooperation along its value chain,” he said. AGENCIES

PM Modi speaks to Saudi Crown Prince, discusses West Asia situation

The prime minister also reiterated India’s condemnation of attacks on regional energy infrastructure

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday spoke to Crown Prince and PM of Saudi Arabia, Prince Mohammed bin Salman, discussed with him the ongoing conflict in West Asia and agreed on the need to ensure freedom of navigation.

In his telephonic conversation with the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia, the prime minister also reiterated India’s condemnation of attacks on regional energy infrastructure.

“Spoke with Crown Prince and PM of Saudi Arabia, HRH Prince Mohammed bin Salman and discussed the ongoing conflict in West Asia,” he said in a post on X.

Modi said both leaders agreed on the need to ensure freedom of navigation and keep shipping lines open and secure.

“Thanked him for his continued support for the welfare of the Indian community in Saudi



Prime Minister Narendra Modi

Arabia,” he said.

This was the second telephonic conversation between the prime minister and the crown prince of Saudi Arabia since the West Asia conflict started on February 28.

While the US and Israel attacked Iran, the Persian nation targeted its neighbours and Israel.

Iran controls the Strait of Hormuz, a key shipping route through which the world’s 20 per cent of energy is trans-

ported. Since the conflict, very few ships are allowed by Iran to cross it.

Modi has also spoken to several world leaders since the conflict started and they include those from the UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, Iran, France, Israel and Malaysia.

US President Donald Trump has also spoken to Modi following which the prime minister said he “had a useful exchange of views on the situation in West Asia”.

Houthis enter fray, Red Sea on edge

Continued from Page 3
D Eisenhower in 2024 and the USS Harry S. Truman in the 2025 campaign against the Houthis.

The Houthis have held Yemen’s capital, Sanaa, since 2014. Saudi Arabia launched a war against the Houthis on behalf of Yemen’s exiled government in 2015 and the rebels had thus far stayed out of the recent conflict due to their uneasy ceasefire with Saudi Arabia.

More than two dozen US troops have been wounded in Iranian attacks on Saudi Arabia’s Prince Sultan Air Base in the past week, according to two people who have been briefed on the matter.

Iran fired six ballistic missiles and 29 drones at the base Friday, injuring at least 15 troops, including five seriously, according to the sources who were not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity.

The base, about 96 kilometres from the Saudi capital of Riyadh, came under attack twice earlier in the week, including a strike that wounded 14 US troops, accord-

ing to the people briefed on the matter. The base is run by the Royal Saudi Air Force but is also used by US troops.

The latest attacks happened after Trump claimed that talks on ending the war were going “very well”. He said he had given Tehran until April 6 to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Iran says it has not engaged in any negotiations.

With the economic repercussions from the war extending far beyond the Middle East, Trump is under growing pressure to end Iran’s chokehold on the strait.

Pakistan said Saturday that Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Egypt will send their top diplomats to Islamabad for talks aimed at ending the war.

Pakistan’s Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said Saturday that he and Iranian President Masoud Peshkian held “extensive discussions” on regional hostilities and efforts aimed at ending the war.

Also Saturday, the Iranian foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, told his Turkish counterpart by phone that Iran was sceptical about recent diplomatic efforts to stop the war. Iranian state-run media reported that

Araghchi accused the United States of making “unreasonable demands” and exhibiting “contradictory actions” that raised doubts about the prospect of an agreement.

Trump envoy Steve Witkoff has said Washington delivered a 15-point “action list” to Iran for a possible ceasefire, with a proposal to restrict Iran’s nuclear programme and reopen the strait.

Tehran rejected the proposal and presented its own five-point proposal that included reparations and recognition of its sovereignty over the waterway.

Meanwhile, US ships drew closer to the region carrying some 2,500 Marines, and at least 1,000 paratroopers from the 82nd Airborne who are trained to land in hostile territory to secure key positions and airfields have been ordered to the Middle East.

Secretary of State Marco Rubio said the US “can achieve all of our objectives without ground troops”.

Iranian authorities say more than 1,900 people have been killed in the Islamic Republic, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel.

What procedure to be adopted in human trafficking cases: SC asks Centre, states

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed the Centre and all the states to inform it about the standard procedure to be adopted in human trafficking cases.

A bench of justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan said it was not interested in any hypothetical or academic formula, but rather a practical approach. It directed the Union home secretary, the home secretaries and the directors general of police of the states and the Union territories, to hold a discussion with all the stakeholders. “The Union of India, the States and the Union Territories are directed to file a detailed affidavit with regard to what standard procedure, according to them, should be adopted in such matters.

“We indicate that the Court is not interested in any hypothetical or academic formula, but rather a practical strategy/ approach which can be implemented/put into place right away, at the local Police Station level under whose juris-

Key Points

- » A bench of justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan said it was not interested in any hypothetical or academic formula, but rather a practical approach
- » The top court said in matters of human trafficking, including child trafficking, time is of the greatest importance
- » The apex court also took exception to some states not appearing despite issuance of notice and sought explanation from all the directors general of police

diction the incident occurs,” the bench said. The top court said in matters of human trafficking, including child trafficking, time is of the greatest importance.

“Thus, whatever guidelines are required/suggestions made, should be after factoring the time frame of the action which the police is required to take immediately upon receipt of a complaint relating to missing of a person. “The Delhi government instructions may also be looked into by the Union, rest of the States and the Union Territories,” the bench said. The top court was hearing a plea filed by senior advocate HS Phoolka regarding human trafficking.

The apex court also took exception to some states not

appearing despite issuance of notice and sought explanation from all the directors general of police.

“Accordingly, personally affirmed affidavit be filed, latest by April 16, 2026, by all the Directors General of Police of the aforesaid States who have not entered appearance to explain the circumstances under which they have chosen not to appear despite notice being issued and duly served to them, failing which they shall be personally present before this court. “We make it clear that if no such affidavit is filed by them till April 16, 2026, no excuse for their non-appearance shall be acceptable,” the bench said.

From Page 3

UAE intercept..

the vicinity of KEZAD, caused by falling debris following the successful interception of a ballistic missile by air defence systems.

On Thursday, an Indian national was among two killed in the UAE when debris of missiles intercepted by the country’s air defence system fell on a street.

The Indian Embassy in the UAE expressed “deepest condolences” on the tragic demise of an Indian national in the incident.

“The Embassy is closely coordinating with the UAE authorities to render all possible support and assistance,” it posted on X.

The second person killed in the incident was a Pakistani national, while the three injured also included an Indian, Abu Dhabi Media Office reported.

Jewar takes wing

development, creating opportunities for the youth and farmers of Uttar Pradesh while benefiting surrounding regions like Agra, Mathura, and Ghaziabad.

PM Modi urged citizens to remain united in the face of global challenges. He said the world is currently witnessing a period of uncertainty due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, which has disrupted supplies of essential commodities such as food items, fuel, fertilisers and gas across several countries.

He called upon the citizens to face such crises collectively, stating that India is responding with full strength while ensuring that the burden does not fall on ordinary families and farmers.

He noted that India imports significant quantities of crude oil and gas from conflict-affected regions and said the government is taking all necessary steps to maintain stability in supplies and prices. Despite global disruptions, he said, the country’s development momentum has continued uninterrupted.

Highlighting infrastructure growth in western Uttar Pradesh, Modi said the airport is the fourth major project launched or inaugurated in the region in recent weeks. He

referred to the foundation of a major semi-conductor facility in Noida, the progress of the Delhi-Meerut Namoo Bharat train, and the expansion of the Meerut Metro as signs of rapid development.

The Prime Minister said Uttar Pradesh has emerged as one of the states with the highest number of international airports in the country. He described the project as a matter of personal pride, noting that he had also laid its foundation stone earlier. He added that the airport strengthens the identity of the state that elected him as a Member of Parliament.

In a participatory gesture during the program, the Prime Minister asked people present to switch on the flashlights of their mobile phones, saying the airport belongs to the public and its inauguration should be shared by all. The crowd responded by lighting up their phones, following which he said every individual present had become part of the inauguration.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath thanked the Prime Minister and said the airport represents the vision of a new India. He said the project will give a new thrust to the state’s growth and reflects the development roadmap implemented over the past decade.

UP Governor Anandiben Patel, and Union aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu were among those present on the occasion.

The Noida International Airport at Jewar is set to become a major driver of economic growth in Uttar Pradesh. Commercial flight operations are expected to commence from April.

Built over 3,300 acres, the first phase of the airport is nearing completion with one terminal and a runway ready for operations. In its initial phase, it is expected to handle nearly 30 million passengers annually, significantly reducing the load on IGI Airport in the national Capital, located about 72 km away. In the long term, the project is planned to expand into one of Asia’s largest aviation hubs, with up to five runways targeted by 2040.

The airport was finally opened after multiple delays. It was first set for a launch on December 1, 2024 which was postponed to April 2025. It was again postponed to September 1, 2025 and then finally to early 2026.

It is set to become the second international airport serving the Delhi-NCR region, after the IGI Airport. The two airports will function as an integrated aviation system

that will ease congestion, expand passenger capacity, and position Delhi-NCR among leading global aviation hubs, the government said in a statement earlier.

Gen Z protest..

“Nobody is above the law,” wrote Home Minister Sudhan Gurung in a social media post after the arrest.

“We have taken under control former Prime Minister KP Oli and former Home Minister Ramesh Lekhak. This is not a revenge against anybody, just the beginning of justice,” he said.

“I believe that now the country will take a new direction,” he added.

Both Oli and Lekhak have been taken into detention at the Kathmandu District Police Circle in Bhadrakali, said the police.

The probe commission has recommended a jail sentence of up to three to ten years for the offence.

A senior police officer at the Kathmandu District Police Circle told PTI that they will be presented before the Kathmandu District Court on Sunday, as it is a holiday on Saturday. Then the process of investigation in the case will start, he added.

K P Oli was taken to Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital for medical examination soon after the detention.

Oli was admitted to the hospital at the advice of the doctors after he was diagnosed with problems related to the heart and kidney, said Senior Superintendent of Police and spokesperson of Kathmandu District Police Circle, Pawan Kumar Bhattarai.

The CPN-UML has opposed the move by the Balen government to arrest party chair Oli and demanded his immediate release.

After the emergency meeting of the central secretariat of the party, UML announced it will organise a countrywide demonstration at 3 p m on Saturday against Oli’s arrest.

The party has also decided to hand over protest letters to Chief District Officers of all 77 districts across Nepal on Sunday. PTI

Just two..

Our prime minister only spoke to Trump and there was no one else who spoke to the PM, people familiar with the matter said.

They suggested that it is for Washington to clarify if somebody else was in the room or listening to the conversation.

The New York Times said Musk’s participation in the phone call signalled a reconciliation between the billionaire and Trump.

The two had fallen out last year following Musk’s exit from a government task force charged with slashing the federal workforce.

The US president had initiated the phone call with Modi to discuss the West Asia crisis.

It was the first conversation between the two leaders since the West Asia conflict began on February 28.

In the conversation, Modi underlined the importance of ensuring that the Strait of Hormuz remains open, secure and accessible, noting that it is vital for global peace, stability and economic well-being. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Maternal deaths..

care, and post-partum follow-up could substantially reduce mortality, especially in countries with the highest burdens, the researchers said.

Furthermore, the COVID-19 infection also led to increases in maternal mortality early in the pandemic.

Before widespread vaccination, during 2020-2021, COVID-19 caused temporary increases in maternal deaths in regions and locations with a high COVID-19 mortality, the team said.

They added that with less than five years remaining to meet the SDG target, a renewed global action and sustained investment will be needed to accelerate progress, strengthen health systems, and improve countries’ ability to monitor and reduce maternal mortality.

Gurugram: 3 lives..

The police arrested, Deepanshu, 25, resident of Gurugram’s Goriyawas village, a senior police officer said, adding that they are questioning the accused.

“We have arrested the accused driver and are questioning him. His medical examination will be conducted soon to clarify whether he had consumed alcohol or not, because the Thar vehicle was at a high speed when the accident happened”, Pataudi SHO Brahm Prakash said.

NOIDA: Welcoming the inauguration of the Noida International Airport, several locals on Saturday urged the government to ensure affordable airfare so that the facility benefits not just the affluent but also the economically weaker sections.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the first phase of the airport on Saturday at Jewar in Gautam Buddh Nagar district.

The project has been developed under a public-private partnership (PPP) model by the Yamuna International Airport Private Limited, a subsidiary of Zurich Airport International AG.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Governor Anandiben Patel, Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu and other dignitaries attended the inauguration ceremony.

Thousands of locals also attended the event and shared their expectations from the airport, with many emphasising the need for affordable air travel.

Sanjay Kumar, a local, said the project would be truly successful only if it became accessible to the common man.

“An airport in Jewar is a very good development. But it will be even better if a person wearing a ‘hawai chappal’ can travel from here,” Kumar said, stressing that the airport has been built with public money and it should benefit all sections of society.

He added that unless the poor are able to use the facility, its success cannot be realised.

Another local said that while the airport would greatly benefit businesspersons and professionals, there should be concessions for those from weaker economic backgrounds.

The project has been developed under a PPP model by the Yamuna International Airport Pvt Ltd, a subsidiary of Zurich Airport International AG

“While people from the middle and upper sections of society will obviously benefit from the project, it would be very helpful if there is some relaxation in ticket prices for those below that level,” he said.

Many attendees were seen carrying large cut-outs of the prime minister and praising the development push in western Uttar Pradesh.

Anchal Rastogi from Meerut said the airport will significantly ease travel for business purposes.

“I am a businessman, and I often travel to different cities for my saree business. It takes a lot of time to reach the Delhi airport, but now it will be much easier to catch flights from here,” he said.

Neetesh from Ghaziabad said the airport would generate employment and boost infrastructure development in the region.

“I came here to see the airport and also because of Modi ji. This is a golden opportunity for the people of Jewar and the nearby areas. It will generate jobs and improve infrastructure,” he said.

The locals said that while the airport is a major step towards development, ensuring affordability would be key to making air travel inclusive and extending its benefits to all sections of society. AGENCIES

Govt lacks courage to oppose Israel’s actions in West Bank: Cong

‘Israel’s attacks on civilians in Gaza continue mercilessly’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Saturday claimed that Israel is moving ahead on its vision of a “Greater Israel” under the cover of the West Asia war, finishing off any hope for a Palestinian state, and slammed Prime Minister Narendra Modi for not raising his voice against its actions in the West Bank.

Congress general secretary in charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said it has been 28 days since the US-Israel aerial bombings of Iran and Iran’s counter-offensive began.

“In the past four weeks, while the world’s gaze has been on the Strait of Hormuz and energy infrastructure in the Gulf countries, Israel has (i) continued its brutalities on the people of Gaza; (ii) begun operations to create a large buffer zone for itself in southern Lebanon; and (iii) taken decisive steps to convert its annexation of the West Bank to firm occupation,” Ramesh said on X.

The current West Asia war is providing cover for Israel to move ahead on its vision of Greater Israel and also finishing off any hope for a Palestin-



A woman carries with others the body of her son, who, according to Palestinian Ministry of Health, was killed in an Israeli army raid, West Bank

HIGHLIGHTS

- ▶ Ramesh said it has been 28 days since the US-Israel aerial bombings of Iran and Iran’s counter-offensive began
- ▶ Congress said the Modi govt has made cynical and hypocritical statements on its commitment to the cause of Palestinians, but in reality, it has abandoned them

ian state, he said.

“The US-Israel bombardment of Iran began just two days after Mr Modi left Israel. What is not realised is that just a few days before he arrived there, the Israeli cabinet had approved land registration in roughly half of the occupied West Bank for the first time since 1967,” Ramesh said.

“This would lead to the dis-

possession of lakhs of Palestinians. But Mr Modi does not have the courage to raise his voice and speak truth to his good friend Benjamin Netanyahu,” the Congress leader said.

The Congress had strongly criticised Prime Minister Modi’s visit to Israel last month, despite that country “mercilessly” continuing attacks on civilians in Gaza.

KOLKATA: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Saturday sought to frame the 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections as a “battle over infiltration, national security and appeasement politics”, while releasing a political “chargesheet” against the TMC government and asserting that the outcome would have implications not only for the state but also for the country’s security.

At a press conference here, Shah mounted a multi-pronged attack on the ruling TMC over infiltration, minority appeasement, corruption, women’s safety, political violence and economic decline, arguing that after 15 years of Mamata Banerjee’s rule, West Bengal had become the country’s “last remaining route” for illegal immigration and a symbol of what he called



Union Home minister Amit Shah addresses the media after releasing a ‘chargesheet’ against the TMC government, in Kolkata, Saturday

“fear, syndicate raj and vote-bank politics”.

In doing so, Shah appeared to unveil a sharper BJP template for West Bengal – one that moves beyond the old promise of ‘Sonar Bangla’ (golden Bengal) and instead seeks to turn the 2026 election into a con-

test over “fear (bhay) and trust (bharosa)”.

“Mamata Didi has always played the politics of the victim card before elections. Sometimes she talks about her injury; sometimes she abuses the Election Commission. But the people of West Bengal now

understand Mamata Didi’s victim card politics very well,” Shah said, accusing her of opposing the SIR exercise only to protect the TMC’s “infiltrator vote bank”.

“The West Bengal elections are important not only for the state but also for the entire country. The nation’s security, in a way, is linked to the West Bengal polls,” he said.

Seeking to make infiltration the central axis of the BJP’s campaign, Shah claimed that after the BJP came to power in Assam, illegal entry routes through that state had been “almost shut”, leaving West Bengal as the principal gateway through which infiltrators enter India and fan out across the country.

“West Bengal is the only state from where infiltrators are entering the country and creating disturbances across the

country. Infiltration from bordering areas of the state is a matter of concern for national security,” he alleged.

Shah claimed that “artificial demographic change” caused by infiltration had left the majority Hindu community living in fear and said, “The 2026 Assembly elections would be a choice between fear and trust.”

The attack was closely tied to Shah’s criticism of Banerjee’s Opposition to the SIR, which the BJP appears keen to make another major plank of its 2026 campaign.

“SIR has taken place in other states too, but nowhere has it been made such an issue. It has become an issue in West Bengal only because Mamata Banerjee wants to protect her vote bank. Abusing constitutional bodies like the EC is not part of Bengali culture,” Shah said.

Punjab: Kejriwal, CM Mann dedicate 109 Aam Aadmi Clinics to people

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FATEHGARH SAHIB: With a major push on its flagship healthcare model in Punjab, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) led Punjab govt on Saturday dedicated 109 new Aam Aadmi Clinics to the people, taking the total number of such clinics in the state to 990 within four years, with 400 more set to be opened in the coming days.

Positioning it as a large-scale expansion of free public healthcare, AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal shared that the clinics are providing 107 medicines and 47 diagnostic tests free of cost, adding that the network has already recorded 5 crore OPD visits.

The AAP chief shared that the government is issuing health cards to 65 lakh families, of which 30 lakh

Kejriwal shared that the government is issuing health cards to 65 lakh families

have already been made and 1.65 lakh people have availed treatment.

Referring to allegations and legal proceedings against him, he said he and other party leaders were jailed in false cases to halt the “politics of work”, adding that the court found no evidence against him and upheld his “kattar imaan-dari” (staunch honesty).

The former Delhi CM also drew a comparison with Delhi, cautioning voters against the BJP and stating that a change in government would lead to the rollback of welfare measures such as free electricity, healthcare, and other public services.

Addressing a massive gathering in Fatehgarh Sahib, Kejriwal stated, “109 new Aam Aadmi Clinics are being inaugurated, where the poor will receive treatment and free medicines. In the last four years, 881 Aam Aadmi Clinics have already been built. Today, 109 more are being added, taking the total to 990 Aam Aadmi Clinics. In the coming days, 400 more Aam Aadmi Clinics will be built, which means there will be around 1500 Aam Aadmi Clinics across Punjab.”

Meanwhile, Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Saturday launched a sharp attack on Sukhbir Singh Badal and the Shiromani Akali Dal over past ‘beadbi’ (sacrilege) incidents, while asserting that the AAP govt is taking decisive steps to ensure justice by strengthening laws and enforcing strict punishment.

CM Sai directs officials to monitor fuel, LPG supply

RAIPUR: Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Saturday directed officials to ensure continuous monitoring of stock and supply of cooking gas and petroleum products, and take strict action against hoarding amid the West Asia conflict.

He said that ensuring timely delivery of essential services to citizens remains the government’s top priority and urged people not to worry.

In a post on X, the chief minister said, “In view of the prevailing situation in West Asia, a review meeting was held today at the Chief Minister’s residence with senior state officials, Commissioners, Inspectors General (IGs), and District Collectors to assess the availability and supply mechanisms of petroleum products, LPG, and essential commodities.”

He said that adequate availability of essential goods, petroleum products, and cooking gas has been ensured across

Chhattisgarh. “The supply chain remains completely smooth and normal, and no shortages of any kind will be allowed to occur,” the CM said.

Officials have been directed to closely monitor stocks and the supply of cooking gas and petroleum products, and to take strict action against hoarding and profiteering, he said.

“Delivering timely services to every citizen of the state remains our utmost priority. The people of the state need not harbor any concerns whatsoever,” he added. Sai also reviewed the law and order situation and directed strict action against those spreading rumours and misleading information.

He instructed the authorities to take immediate and stringent action against any attempts at hoarding, black marketing or creating artificial shortages, officials said.



सत्यमेव जयते

Ministry of Civil Aviation
Government of India

Strengthening Aviation by Promoting Inlusivity and Enhancing Infrastructure

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Hon'ble Prime Minister

Inauguration/Dedication of

UDAN Yatri Cafe, Passenger Facilities and Infrastructure Upgradation Works at Various Airports

by

Shri Rammohan Naidu Kinjarapu

Union Minister of Civil Aviation

Sunday, 29th March, 2026 | 10:30 AM | Rajkot International Airport, Gujarat



UDAN YATRI CAFE: Offering affordable snack options - Chandigarh, Amritsar, Rajkot, Jammu, Varanasi, Patna, Indore, Gwalior, Jaipur, Agartala and Lucknow



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Kids' Zone: Interactive play area for kids - Chandigarh, Adampur, Bathinda, Khajuraho, Jammu, Dehradun, Amritsar, Imphal, Gwalior and Agartala



Flybrary: The enjoyment of reading during travel- Chandigarh, Adampur, Amritsar, Bareilly, Hindon, Jammu, Khajuraho, Prayagraj, Srinagar, Imphal, Indore, Agartala, Jamnagar, Dehradun, Kullu and Kishangarh



AVSAR: Empowering local artisans by showcasing their products - Chandigarh, Jammu, Khajuraho, Kullu(Bhuntar), Varanasi, Imphal, Indore, Gwalior, Jabalpur, Agartala and Jamnagar



Infrastructure Upgradation: Boosting operational efficiency of airports - Jodhpur, Srinagar, Bhubaneswar, Darbhanga, Jharsuguda, Imphal, Indore and Bhopal



Wi-Fi: Staying connected while on travel - Adampur, Agartala, Agra, Aligarh, Amritsar, Ayodhya, Azamgarh, Bareilly, Bhubaneswar, Bikaner, Chandigarh, Chitrakoot, Darbhanga, Dehradun, Deogarh, Dimapur, Gaya, Gorakhpur, Hindon, Hisar, Hollongi, Imphal, Indore, Jaisalmer, Jammu, Jharsuguda, Jodhpur, Kangra(Gaggal), Kanpur(Chakeri), Khajuraho, Kishangarh, Kullu(Bhuntar), Kushinagar, Leh, Ludhiana, Moradabad, Pakyong, Pant Nagar, Pathankot, Patna, Port Blair, Prayagraj, Purnea, Raipur, Shillong, Shimla, Srinagar, Tezu, Udaipur and Varanasi



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Kohli-ty time in Bengaluru

Kohli and Padikkal make opening statement as RCB roars back

S KANNAN

BENGALURU: It was a battling carnage at the Chinnaswamy Stadium on Saturday night as defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB), led by Devdutt Padikkal and Virat Kohli, thumped Sunrisers Hyderabad by six wickets in the IPL 2026 season opener.

The match carried an added emotional weight, following the tragic stampede at the stadium on June 4, 2025, which claimed 11 lives and injured many more. Eleven empty chairs were placed in the arena as a mark of respect, while players from both sides wore black armbands, honoring the fans who make the sport what it is. Months of uncertainty had clouded RCB's preparations, with questions over whether the team could deliver in Bengaluru and how they would perform under heightened scrutiny.

Security was tighter than ever. With crowd-control concerns and law-and-order considerations, the Karnataka government ensured a seamless experience with cops, cameras, and manned gates, leaving nothing to chance. Once inside, the stadium came alive in a 'sea of red', reflecting RCB's signature colors and the electric



RCB's Devdutt Padikkal and Virat Kohli during the chase

PTI

anticipation of fans.

After winning the toss, RCB captain Rajat Patidar elected to field first.

Sunrisers' openers fell early, but stand-in captain Ishan Kishan fought back with a belligerent 80 off 38 balls, including eight fours and five sixes, taking SRH to 201/9—a total RCB would chase convincingly.

Padikkal led the chase in spectacular fashion, smashing 61 off just 26 balls with seven boundaries and four sixes. Patidar contributed a quick-

21
Balls taken by Padikkal for his half-century - his fastest in the IPL

fire 31, while Kohli's 69-run masterclass reminded fans why he remains a T20 force at 35. With runs flowing freely

and the SRH attack struggling, RCB wrapped up a comfortable six-wicket victory, reaffirming their dominance and silencing doubts about their return to Chinnaswamy after months of uncertainty.

The atmosphere in the stadium, reminiscent of the team's glory days, captured the essence of IPL cricket—high stakes, skill, emotion, and sheer entertainment. The opening night belonged to RCB—the champions had returned, and the IPL stage lit up once again.

Dhoni set to miss two weeks

NEW DELHI: Chennai Super Kings icon MS Dhoni is set to miss the first two weeks of the IPL due to a calf injury, the franchise said on Saturday. "MS Dhoni is currently undergoing rehabilitation for a calf strain. As a result, he is likely to miss the first two weeks of TATA IPL 2026," said CSK in a statement.

Dhoni has continued playing the IPL ever since retiring from international cricket in 2020.

The 44-year-old's future in the IPL becomes a topic of intense discussion following CSK's campaign every season. Considering Dhoni only plays the IPL, it becomes tougher to maintain match fitness. Though Ruturaj Gaikwad is the captain of the side, Dhoni is the de facto leader of the franchise having stayed with them since 2008 barring the time they were suspended from the competition. AGENCIES

MI HAVE GOOD ALL-ROUND STRENGTH

Rohit 2.0 in focus as MI eye perfect start vs depleted KKR

MUMBAI: A robust Mumbai Indians' outfit will begin their bid to end a five-year title drought in the Indian Premier League when they take on a depleted Kolkata Knight Riders in their tournament opener here on Sunday.

It has been a while since Mumbai Indians, the joint most successful team in the IPL, laid their hands on a trophy which they claimed five times between 2013-2020.

Last year, the Hardik Pandya-led side finished third after losing to runners-up Punjab Kings in the Qualifier 2 but Mumbai Indians will feel they have all bases covered to have a crack at what would be a record-extending sixth title win this year.

A new-look Rohit Sharma will be keen to be back among runs while Mumbai Indians' all-round strength makes them a side to beat in the tournament once again. It includes a heavy chunk of India's T20 World Cup winning squad in skipper Suryakumar Yadav, Pandya, Tilak Varma and Jasprit Bumrah.

MI's rich overseas talent bench consists of another wicketkeeper-batter option in Ryan Rickelton, Sherfane Rutherford, Corbin Bosch, New Zealand skipper Mitchell Santner,



Rohit Sharma bats at nets during training

FILE

Last year, the Hardik Pandya-led side finished third after losing in Qualifier 2

Will Jacks, AM Ghazanfar and even Trent Boult, who is will be expected to team up with Bumrah.

In Shardul Thakur and Deepak Chahar, MI have two seasoned Indian operators while Naman Dhir could once again continue playing the role of a finisher which he executed with a lot of success last year.

The challenge, thus, will not only be to find the right playing combination and utilise that

Impact Player rule to their benefit but also to notch up a few wins at the start which gives them a momentum, as IPL's perennial slow-starters Mumbai Indians are notorious on this aspect. The visitors Kolkata Knight Riders carry some local flavour in skipper Ajinkya Rahane and the young Angkrish Raghuvanshi to Mumbai but they have some pertinent questions to answer even before the first ball has begun.

The biggest task for the KKR leadership group would be to zero in on a bowling attack which looks far too different than what they would have envisaged after the auction.

Mustafizur Rahman was released by the franchise on BCCI's instructions. AGENCIES

'GOING TO HAVE ONE SQUAD' - Buttlar opts for work-life balance amid T20 boom



Gujarat Titans' Jos Buttler during a practice session on Saturday

PTI

NEW DELHI: How much cricket is too much cricket?

Jos Buttler says it depends completely on an individual and his ability to at times say "no" to some of the T20 franchise league offers which helps in finding the perfect work-life balance.

Come September, Buttler, one of England's finest white-ball keeper-batters, will turn 36 but he is still managing his white ball career for England while also playing his trade as a sought-after T20 smasher for the 11th successive season in the cash-rich Indian Premier League. It will be his second season with Gujarat Titans.

So has he come to a stage where he might have to choose between club and country?

"I am just trying to be very immediate actually with my stuff and just be where my feet are. Look at what's in front of me and play accordingly. Obviously the IPL is the thing right now," Buttler told PTI during an exclusive interaction ahead of team's first match against Punjab Kings on Tuesday.

For Buttler, it is important to know what is one's priority professionally as well as personally and then take an informed call.

"After a period of time, you

“After a period of time, you reflect and say, okay, where am I at with my career? What's important to me?”
— Jos Buttler

reflect and say, okay, where am I at with my career? What's important to me? Obviously, I only play white-ball cricket for England. So I have a calendar now that I feel like I can manage relatively well," said Buttler.

"Alongside the franchise stuff, there are things I've turned down to spend time at home because that's very important to me. I need to maintain energy and relationships and that kind of thing," he said.

Right now, there are way too many T20 leagues happening and Buttler thinks that the "onus is also on the players, to be honest, to be disciplined enough to sometimes say no to something." AGENCIES

Winning start to season for Tejaswin in decathlon

NEW DELHI: India's Tejaswin Shankar started his decathlon season on a winning note at the David Noble Relays 2026 athletics meet in Texas, USA, emerging victorious in the event with a new wind-assisted personal best of 7947 points.

Shankar falling 53 points short of 8000m mark in a wind-aided competition on Friday. Shankar's effort in Texas was better than the standing national record of 7826 points, which he himself set in Poland last year, but it was not ratified as a new record as per the World Athletics Rules because of excessive tail winds.

According to World Athletics rules, decathlon records require the average wind assistance across the 100m, long jump, and 110m hurdles to not exceed +2.0 m/s.

In the Texas meet, the 100m (+4.7 m/s) and Long Jump (+4.5 m/s) readings significantly exceeded the legal limits. In Shankar's case, the tailwind during the 100m event was +4.7m/s, the long jump event was +4.5m/s and the 110m hurdles event was +2.5m/s, taking the average to +3.9m/s. AGENCIES

'Pant's openness to feedback helps'

NEW DELHI: Mitchell Marsh has heaped praise on Rishabh Pant's leadership, saying the skipper's openness to suggestions has been a key factor behind the positive environment within the Lucknow Super Giants camp.

LSG have two international captains in Marsh and Aiden Markram.

"It's just about contributing as best you can, being the best support possible for Rishabh. He's a great young guy who leads his team really well. He's always open to feedback, suggestions, and takes on board whatever you say," Marsh said. "We've got some really good leaders within

the group, which you need. And for me, it's about contributing where needed."

Emphasising his own approach, Marsh underlined that consistency and team impact remain his primary focus. "Just staying consistent with the way I prepare. Last year was obviously a good year for me personally in terms of my consistency. But the main thing for me is just, how can I impact this team positively and contribute to us winning as many games as possible." Marsh also pointed to the role played by team owner Sanjiv Goenka and Pant in fostering a positive atmosphere. AGENCIES

Praggnanandhaa braces for tough challenge as Candidates set to begin

PAPHOS: Grandmaster R Praggnanandhaa, India's sole representative in the Open section of the eight-player elite field, faces a challenging task as the Candidates Tournament gets underway here on Sunday.

The event, which will determine over the course of a fortnight the challenger to reigning world champion D Gukesh in the next World Championship match later this year, will feature eight players competing in a double round-robin format.

Each player will face every other participant twice, and the one with the highest total points will earn the right to compete for the world title.

Going by recent form, American GM Fabiano Caruana appears to be the favourite, ahead of compatriot Hikaru Nakamura, who qualified through his rating. Dutch Grandmaster Anish Giri has also been in good form and is one to watch; if he gets going, he will be a formidable contender.

Wei Yi of China, Javokhir Sindarov of Uzbekistan, Andrey Esipenko, and Matthias Bluebaum are the other four players in what is likely to be one of the most keenly contested and widely followed tournaments of the year.



R Praggnanandhaa is India's sole representative in the Open section

FILE

Going by recent form, American GM Fabiano Caruana appears to be the favourite

For Praggnanandhaa, the lead-up to the Candidates has not been entirely smooth. However, the Indian should feel refreshed after a well-deserved long break; since the Tata Steel Chess Tournament in February, the young Grandmaster has not played any competitive chess and has instead been preparing for this event with his team. After an impressive 2025, in which he qualified for the Candidates by finishing as the

top performer on the FIDE circuit, the latter part of the year saw an unusual dip in Praggnanandhaa's form, a trend that continued into the Tata Steel Masters earlier this year.

The Indian will be hoping to turn the tide and make things fall as per his scheme.

The dark horse of the event is the youngest participant, Sindarov, who surprised everyone by winning the Chess World Cup in Goa late last year. Sindarov possesses both the acumen and the fighting spirit to go the distance, and although this is his first Candidates appearance, the Uzbek will be raring to go.

Wei Yi can be tricky but much would depend on how many games he wins. AGENCIES

Miami Open: Sinner in final, one win away from Federer's record

MIAMI GARDENS: Jan-nik Sinner sat out the Miami Open a year ago as he served a three-month suspension after testing positive for a banned substance.

Now the 24-year-old Italian is on the verge of winning his second Miami Open title in three years and becoming the first male to win the "Sunshine Double" since Roger Federer in 2017.

The second-ranked Sinner roared into the Miami Open final with a 6-3, 7-6 (7-4) win over No. 4 Alexander Zverev on Friday night at Hard Rock Stadium. "Coming here and trying to produce some good tennis was my main goal, and standing here again in the final means very much to me," Sinner said. "It has been an incredible swing and I couldn't be better. I'm very happy."

Sinner, who served 15 aces, has beaten Zverev seven straight times and has won a record 32 straight sets at an ATP Masters 1000. A hard-court dynamo, Sinner captured the first leg of the Sunshine Double on March 15 when he topped Daniel Medvedev in Indian Wells.



Jannik Sinner beat Alexander Zverev in three sets

AP/PTI

Sinner will be a heavy favorite when he faces 21st-seeded Jiri Lehecka in Sunday's final. Sinner has won 11 straight matches in Miami dating to 2024. He captured the 2024 Miami Open but wasn't allowed to defend his title.

Nevertheless, Zverev was the crowd favorite, particularly drawing loud cheers on points he won in the second set.

When the 6-foot-6 German got up a break point leading 4-3 in the second set, the stadium was awash in noise. But Zverev couldn't pull it off, hitting a backhand into the net as Sinner escaped. AGENCIES

Men's relay teams take a major step forward

CHANDIGARH: India's men's 4x400m and mixed 4x100m relay teams took a major step toward qualification to the World Athletics Relays in Botswana in May, delivering standout performances at the International Invitation Relay Competition here on Saturday.

The men's 4x400m squad, featuring Manu TS, Amoj Jacob, D Chaudhary, and Rajesh Ramesh, secured gold with a time of 3:01.43 seconds. The performance significantly bolsters their standing as they push for a spot in the World Athletics Relays, scheduled for May 2-3 in Gaborone, Botswana.

In the mixed 4x100m relay, the National B team stole the show by shattering the national record. The quartet clocked 42.30 seconds, erasing the previous mark of 43.44 seconds set by Tamil Nadu in 2025.

The India A team followed closely in second at 42.34 seconds, while the Maldives took third.

Chief athletics coach Radhakrishnan Nair praised the depth of the field, noting that both Indian entries performed "exceedingly well".

However, the day was marked by "heartbreak" for the men's 4x100m relay team. A disqualification in the heats ended their hopes of qualifying for the World Relays. National

The men's 4x400m squad, featuring Manu TS, Amoj Jacob, D Chaudhary, and Rajesh Ramesh, secured gold with a time of 3:01.43 seconds.

record holder Animesh Kujur expressed his disappointment, noting that the Chandigarh meet was the final opportunity to improve their ranking before the April 5 deadline.

The Athletics Federation of India (AFI) fielded two teams in the mixed 4x100m relay, and members of both teams did exceedingly well, chief athletics coach Radhakrishnan Nair said.

However, India's international sprinter and national record holder, Animesh Kujur was disappointed at missing a golden chance to board the flight to Botswana.

"The competition in Chandigarh was the last chance for the 4x100m relay squad to improve their world ranking before the deadline of April 5, but we missed," Kujur, a member of the national 4x100m relay team," he said. AGENCIES

SAFF U20 C'ship: Colts top group

MALÉ: The Indian U20 men's team finished as Group B top-pers after playing out a 1-1 draw against Bangladesh in their second match of the SAFF U20 Championship 2026 here on Saturday.

Vishal Yadav handed the Blue Colts the lead in the 17th minute, but Bangladesh struck deep into first-half stoppage time through Md Abdul Riyad Fahim (45+10) to ensure the points were shared.

The result was enough for India to stay on top of the group, having already secured qualification for the semi-finals following their 3-0 win over Pakistan. Bangladesh finished runners-up due to an inferior goal difference. Mahesh Gawali's side will now face Bhutan in the semi-final on Wednesday, while Bangladesh will take on Nepal.

The match began cautiously, with both sides keen to avoid early mistakes. Bangladesh attempted to stretch India's defence by using the breadth of the pitch, but the Indian backline remained compact and organised, limiting clear-cut chances. India gradually grew into the game, building patiently from the back and looking to make set-pieces count. The breakthrough arrived in the 17th minute. AGENCIES

Germany's Wirtz destroys Swiss and White caps England return as hero

LONDON: Mikel Oyarzabal scored two impressive goals in Spain's 3-0 win over Serbia, and Florian Wirtz scored two and made two more as Germany twice came from behind to beat Switzerland 4-3, in entertaining pre-World Cup friendlies on Friday.

In other games, Ben White scored on his recall to the England side and then gave away a penalty in stoppage time as England drew 1-1 with Uruguay, while the Netherlands overcame Norway 2-1 in Amsterdam.

White was a controversial selection by England coach Thomas Tuchel, four years after walking out on his teammates in the middle of the last World Cup. The Arsenal defender replaced Fikayo Tomori with 21 minutes left in a dull match on Friday and his appearance

Wirtz's wizardry casts spell



Mikel Oyarzabal scored two in Spain's 3-0 win over Serbia

AP

was greeted with some boos from the 80,000 fans present at Wembley.

"He needs to take it on the chin," Tuchel said. "We will always protect him and hope-

fully we can put it behind (us) because he is ready to write some new chapters and we are ready to give him the chance, so hopefully everyone can move on and accept it."

However, White was in the right place at the right time 10 minutes from time to give England the lead after Cole Palmer's corner was flicked on and White poked the ball in at the

11
Real Sociedad striker Oyarzabal has scored a stunning 11 times in last 10 games for Spain

far post for what will surely be one of the easiest goals of his career.

Uruguay did not have a shot on goal and that looked like being the winner, only for White to clip Federico Viñas in the box as the clock ticked past 90 minutes.

The referee pointed to the spot after a video review and Federico Valverde converted for Uruguay to leave the scores level.

It was the first goal that England has conceded in seven games and the decision left the coach and players furious, with Tuchel declaring it "not a penalty."

Harry Maguire shared that opinion and was even more upset about the referee's lack of action in dealing a rash challenge by Ronaldo Araujo on Phil Foden. AGENCIES

Can MI finally win opener? Jayawardene hopeful of ending jinx

MUMBAI: Mumbai Indians head coach Mahela Jayawardene believes there is only one way to break the team's 13-year opening-day 'hoodoo' in the IPL: play a good game of cricket. Speaking on Saturday, Jayawardene insisted that despite failing to win a season opener since 2012, the team's preparation remains focused on execution. MI, the perennial slow-starters, last won their opening match in the IPL in April 2012, when they beat Chennai Super Kings by eight wickets. As they gear up to take on three-time winners Kolkata Knight Riders here on Sunday, the very first question Jayawardene took was whether MI would break that jinx this time around. It is the elephant in the room but there is no way for us to prepare differently," Jayawardene told reporters at the Wankhede Stadium ahead of MI's training session. "If you look at the season that I was involved in, we had close matches, we lost. I think I have spoken to the boys about the intensity being there for that first game. I think that is all we can control."

I have spoken to the boys about the intensity being there for that first game. I think that is all we can control

— Mahela Jayawardene, MI head coach

"That is what I have asked from the guys to go out and play a good game of cricket at that high intensity. Other than that, I don't see how else we could prepare because we pretty much prepare for each and every game the same way. Hopefully, I can break that hoodoo," he said. Jayawardene, nevertheless, was pleased to have a robust squad comprising several current and past captains from international circuit under one roof. "It is great to have all this experience; every-one brings that element," he added.

**NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**

Letter No. : **DRM/CI/AGRA/NFRE/AUCTION** Dated : 25.03.2026

E-Auction Notice

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per category given as under:-

Category : Misc-Static-Services **Catalogue No. :** MSS-AGRA-MTJ-TWnOPS-2-26-1

Asset Details : Two wheeler parcel packing service at Mathura Junction railway station.

E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 09.04.2026 Time : 11:00

E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 09.04.2026 Time : 11:30

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **676/26 (AS)**

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 

पुलिस मुख्यालय (तकनीकी सेवाएं) मध्य प्रदेश, भोपाल :
:: नदीन अंजन क्षेत्रीय न्यायालयिक विभाग प्रयोगशाला मदददा रेल भोपाल ::
(फोन नं. 0435-230006) ई-मेल nsrtech-cdr@mponline.gov.in)

क्रमांक/तक-सेवाएं/एफएसएल/का- /83 /26 भोपाल, दिनांक- 18/03/2026

// विज्ञापन //

मध्य प्रदेश न्यायालयिक विभाग प्रयोगशाला के अराजकपत्रित सेवा गृह (पुलिस) विभाग अंतर्गत प्रयोगशाला तकनीशियन, प्रयोगशाला सहायक एवं प्रयोगशाला परिचारक की भर्ती वर्ष-2026 हेतु एम.पी.ऑनलाईन के चयन पोर्टल के माध्यम से ऑनलाईन आवेदन आमंत्रित किये जाते हैं, इच्छुक आवेदक विस्तृत विज्ञापन एम.पी.ऑनलाईन की वेबसाइट chayan.mponline.gov.in पर देख सकते हैं।

(के.पी.वैकाटेश्वर राय) मा.पु.से
अतिरिक्त पुलिस महानिदेशक
(तकनीकी सेवाएं)
G27949/25
पुलिस मुख्यालय, भोपाल

"स्वायत्त स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Shohib Khan, S/o Lt. Sh. Fayyaz Khan, R/o:** House No. C-1542, Gali No. 4, Mulla Colony, Ghazoli Ext. Gazipur East Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 15063/2021 U/s 379 IPC, PS Gazipur, East Distt. Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Shohib Khan** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Shohib Khan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Shohib Khan** the said accused of **FIR No. 15063/2021 U/s 379 IPC, PS Gazipur, East Distt. Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.04.2026**.

By Order
Sachin,
DP/4035/ED/2026
(Court Matter)

JMFC-03, East Distt., Court No. 16,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

CHANGE OF NAME

I, MADHU W/O SH. SHANKAR LAL R/O 311/319, JATTON WALI GALI RITHALA VILLAGE NORTH WEST DELHI, DELHI-110085 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM MADHU SINGAL TO MADHU FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. I ALSO DECLARE THAT MADHU SINGAL AND MADHU ARE THE SAME AND ONE PERSON.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, SHANKAR LAL S/O LATE SH. MANGAT RAM R/O 311/319, JATTON WALI GALI RITHALA VILLAGE NORTH WEST DELHI, DELHI-110085 HAVE CHANGED MY NAME FROM SHANKAR LAL SINGAL TO SHANKAR LAL FOR ALL FUTURE PURPOSES. I ALSO DECLARE THAT SHANKAR LAL AND SHANKAR LAL SINGAL ARE THE SAME AND ONE PERSON.

I ALSO DECLARE THAT MY FATHER'S CORRECT NAME IS LATE SH. MANGAT RAM. I ALSO DECLARE THAT LATE SH. MANGAT RAM AND LATE SH. MANGAT RAM SINGAL WAS THE SAME AND ONE PERSON.

I ALSO DECLARE THAT MY MOTHER'S CORRECT NAME IS LATE MANBHAVATI DEVI. I ALSO DECLARE THAT LATE MANBHAVATI DEVI AND LATE MANBHAVATI DEVI SINGAL WAS THE SAME AND ONE PERSON.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that two accused persons, namely **1, Majid, S/o:** Arshad, **R/o:** H.No.-32/389, Trilokpur, Delhi, and accused **person 2, Jaichand @ Lalla, S/o:** Gokul Chand, **R/o:** H.No.- E-25/B-1, Indra Camp, Trilokpur, Delhi, have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 43/2024, U/s: 454/380/411/34 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Badarpur, New Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that both the said accused persons, **Majid** and **Jaichand @ Lalla**, and cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that both the said accused persons, **Majid** and **Jaichand @ Lalla**, have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that both the said accused persons, **Majid** and **Jaichand @ Lalla**, **FIR No. 43/2024, U/s: 454/380/411/34 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Badarpur, New Delhi**, are required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Vinod Joshi
Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate
South-East District, Court No. 515
Saket Courts, New Delhi

DP/4008/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSONS

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused persons (**1) Ram Bahadur S/o Sher Bahadur (2) Anil Bahadur S/o Khuman Singh (3) Prem Bahadur S/o Gaurakh Bahadur (4) Rajender Bahadur S/o Sher Bahadur, all Resident of Tiwari ka makan, Village Bhowapur, Ghaziabad, U.P. and (5) Sagar Kumar S/o Prashant Kumar R/o Jhuggi No. N23, Khilona Bagh, Model Town, Delhi** have committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence case **FIR No. 82/2017 u/s 380/457/411/34 IPC at P.S. Model Town, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the **above said accused** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the **above said accused** have absconded (or are concealing themselves to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s **84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita** has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the (**1) Ram Bahadur, (2) Anil Bahadur, (3) Prem Bahadur, (4) Rajender Bahadur and (5) Sagar Kumar** accused of **FIR No. 82/2017 u/s 380/457/411/34 IPC at P.S. Model Town, Delhi** are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **12.05.2026**.

By Order: **Shri Himanshu Selhott,**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03,
North, Court No. 213,
Rohini Courts, Delhi.

DP/3802/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Hari Singh S/o Ganga Lal R/o Khasra No. 120/13, D-Block, Gali No. 24, West Kamal Vihar, Burari, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 357/2025 U/s 420/34 IPC, PS Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Hari Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Hari Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Hari Singh in FIR No. 357/2025 U/s 420/34 IPC, PS Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.04.2026**.

By order
Ms Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Court No. 06
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/3916/NW/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-I/NT, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1	Name of work	Improvement of Akshardham ranney well premises including construction of Boundary wall for safety to Prevent Trespassing, Construction of RCC Road Parallel to Line for Proper Maintenance, Renovation of Pump House and Repairing of Road for proper access to Ranney well and Repair and renovation work of the parcel area (inward and outward) at NDLS including construction of a shed near PF- 16, replacement and repair of damaged roofing sheets and FRP valley gutter along with white-washing, painting and general renovation of the sick line and office and misc. works such as drain covering in the section of SSE/W/NDLS section under ADEN/NDLS.		
2	Approx. Cost of Work	Rs. 3,98,12,795.83/- (Rupees Three Crore Ninety Eight Lakh Twelve Thousand Seven Hundred Ninety Five and Eighty Three Paise Only)		
3	Earnest Money to be deposited	Rs. 3,49,100,000/- (Rupees Three Lakh Forty Nine Thousand One Hundred Only)		
4	Cost of tender document	Rs. 0.00		
5	Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender	20.04.2026 at 15:00 Hrs.		
6	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in		
7	Allocation	04-510-32		

• The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system.
• For all terms and conditions, please refer tender document. • No manual offers are acceptable. • Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No.: 128-W/280/eTender Notice/NIT/57/2025-26/W-3 Dated: 27.03.2026
1043/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS!

INTRODUCTION OF NEW WEEKLY EXPRESS TRAIN BETWEEN ANAND VIHAR (T) - PURULIA JN.-ANAND VIHAR (T)

It is notified for the information of all concerned that Railways will introduce the regular run of Train No. **14022/14021 New Express Train (Weekly) between Anand Vihar (T) - Purulia Jn. -Anand Vihar (T) stations as per following, time-table & stoppages:-**

Train No. 14022/14021 Anand Vihar (T) - Purulia Jn. - Anand Vihar (T) Express (Weekly)					
Train No. 14022		STATIONS		Train No. 14021	
ARR.	DEP.			ARR.	DEP.
--	05:00	↓	Anand Vihar (T)	23:10	--
08:15	08:25		Moradabad	19:38	19:48
10:10	10:15		Bareilly Jn.	17:46	17:48
14:20	14:30		Lucknow Jn.	13:05	13:15
16:25	16:30		Ayodhya Cantt	10:25	10:30
21:40	21:50		Varanasi Jn.	07:10	07:15
22:40	22:45		Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn.	05:40	05:45
23:24	23:26		Bhabua Road	04:35	04:37
23:53	23:55		Sasaram	03:52	03:54
00:08	00:10		Dehri-on-Son	03:30	03:32
00:55	00:57		Japla	02:15	02:17
02:30	02:35		Garwa Road Jn.	01:40	01:45
03:13	03:15		Daltonganj	00:30	00:32
03:43	03:45		Barwadih Jn.	00:01	00:03
04:20	04:22		Latehar	22:55	22:57
05:15	05:17		Tori	22:15	22:17
06:00	06:02		Lohardaga	21:10	21:12
07:20	07:30		Ranchi	19:35	19:45
08:40	08:42		Muri	18:18	18:20
10:40	--		Purulia Jn.	--	17:00

Days of Run : **14022 Ex Anand Vihar (T)** from 02.04.2026 (every Thursday) and **14021 Purulia Jn.** from 03.04.2026 (every Friday).
Accommodation: 1AC, AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, Sleeper & General.

For any kind of information and detailed time-table etc. passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.

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NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGGSU-2026-02 Dated: 26.03.2026

E-TENDERING NOTICE

Chief Project Manager, Gati Shakti, North Central Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

Description of Work: Balance work for KHAJURAHO: Provision of chord line from Mahoba line to Lalitpur line.

Approx Cost (Rs.)	₹ 13957714.93	Earnest Money (Rs.)	₹ 219800
Date of Closing Tender: 16.04.2026			
Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: 06 Months			

• Tender on line can be submitted upto 10.30 hrs. on 16.04.2026.
• For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in **678/26 (A)**

  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Letter No:- DRM/CI/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026 Dated : 25.03.2026

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category :	Parking	Auction Catalogue No. :	PARKING-2026-08
Asset Details : Achhnera Jn. Railway Station, Circulating Area-Cycle, Scooter, Motor cycle & Car Parking.		E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:00	E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:30
Asset Details : Mathura Jn. Railway Station 2ed Entry-Passenger Carrying Commercial Vehicles (PCV) parking i.e. Bus, Autos, Taxis (Cars), Parking for location Circulating Area.		E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:00	E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:40

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wises details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **672/26 (C)**

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Ganesh Thapa S/o Sh. Suraj Thapa R/o H. No. RZ-57, Deep Enclave, Part-III, Vikas Nagar, Uttam Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 699/2019 U/s 420/467/468/471 IPC PS: Ranhola, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ganesh Thapa** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ganesh Thapa** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ganesh Thapa** accused of **FIR No. 699/2019 U/s 420/467/468/471 IPC PS: Ranhola, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Ankit Karan Singh
JMFC - 08 West, Court No. 30
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/3885/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that that accused **Naresh, S/o:** Ramesh, **R/o:** H.No. H-1st/268, Madangir, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 20/2026 U/s 20 NDPS Act & 112 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Ambedkar Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Naresh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Naresh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Naresh** accused of offence in case **FIR No. 20/2026 U/s 20 NDPS Act & 112 Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, P.S.: Ambedkar Nagar, Delhi** and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **04.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Gaurav Gupta
Additional Session Judge/
Special Judge-NDPS (South)
Room No. 505, Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/3717/SD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Date: 25.03.2026

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invite open Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

E-Tender No.: JHS-N-W-26-26 **Approx Cost : Rs. 2277074.36/-**

Description of work : Reliability improvement for MSDAC with the segregation of Quad cable and power supply for remaining A/C over Jhansi division.

Earnest Money : Rs. 251400/- **Cost of Tender form : Nil**

Opening of tender : 16.04.2026 Time 15:00

Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance : 12 Months

• Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 16.04.2026.
• For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. (NORTH CENTRAL RLY/JHANSI DIVISION-SAND T) **681/26 (D)**

  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice No.- JHS-N-W-27-26

Date- 26.03.2026

E-TENDERING NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invites open Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

E-Tender No.- JHS-N-W-27-26

Description of work: Provision of RCC boundary wall along the track on approaches in VGLJ-DHO Section of Jhansi Division for financial year 2025-26.

Approx. Cost	Earnest Money	Cost of Tender Form
₹ 17959522.50/-	₹ 239800/-	Nil

Opening of tender: 24.04.2026 Time 15.00, Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance: 12 Months.

• Tender on line can be submitted upto 15.00 hrs on 24.04.2026 • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. (NORTH CENTRAL RLY/JHANSI DIVISION-SAND T) **682/26 FA**

  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tender Notice

Tender Notice No. : 79-Elect/G/PRY/J25-26 Dated : 25.03.2026

Senior Divl. Electrical Engineer/Gen/N.C.Rly/Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invite the following e-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 15:00 hrs. on 20.04.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-

TN : ELG-159-2526	Cost of work (In Rs.) : 4501255.89
Name of work : Electrical work in connection with the work of "Prayagraj-Improvement to DRM Office building & campus".	
Bid Security (in Rs.) : 90000.00	Duration of completion : 06 Month
TN : ELG-160-2526	Cost of work (In Rs.) : 6202972.30
Name of work : Electrical work in connection with the work of "AAP-SB: Provision of water supply arrangement with submersible pump at way side colony under ADEN/ETW.". Electrical work in connection with the work of "Firozabad-Construction of underground water tank connected with JEDDAH JHAL Pariyojana at Firozabad station.". Electrical work in connection with the work of "Construction work of RPF POST PHD Office."	
Bid Security (in Rs.) : 124100.00	Duration of completion : 06 Month

Tender Opening Date : 20.04.2026, 15:00 Hrs

Note : 1. The complete information along with tender document of above e-Tender is available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs. on the due date of tender opening. **680/26 (C)**

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 

**UJVN LIMITED**

H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

Letter No: 260 Dated: 28/03/2026

Tender Notice

Office of the Executive Engineer (Generation), Khodri Power Station, Dakpathar (Dehradun), invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:-
Tender No: 16/EE(Gen)/Khodri/2025-26: Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning (SITC) of four(04) numbers 10kVA, 11,000/110V dry-type Neutral Grounding Transformers at Khodri Power Station.
Tender No: 17/EE(Gen)/Khodri/2025-26: Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) of 04 No's 34 MVA Transformer PLC based Oil Pump control panel System installed at Khodri power station.
Estimated cost: Rs. 24,98,900/- & Rs. 9,78,780/-GST extra.
Date of availability of bid document on website: 30.03.2026, 10:00 hrs.
Last date for submission of tender: 20.04.2026 up to 16:00 hrs.
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvn.com"

Executive Engineer (Generation)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Letter No:- DRM/CI/AGRA/PARKING/E-AUCTION/2026 Dated : 25.03.2026

On Behalf of the President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager-North Central Railway-Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category :	Parking	Auction Catalogue No. :	PARKING-2026-08
Asset Details : Achhnera Jn. Railway Station, Circulating Area-Cycle, Scooter, Motor cycle & Car Parking.		E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:00	E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:30
Asset Details : Mathura Jn. Railway Station 2ed Entry-Passenger Carrying Commercial Vehicles (PCV) parking i.e. Bus, Autos, Taxis (Cars), Parking for location Circulating Area.		E-Auction Start Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:00	E-Auction End Date and Time : Date : 16.04.2026 Time : 12:40

Note : Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wises details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. **672/26 (C)**

 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

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 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in 

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Mrityunjai @ Mukul S/o Pawan Rohilla R/o D-507, Gali No. 12, Bhajanpura, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 430/2022 U/s 325/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mrityunjai @ Mukul** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mrityunjai @ Mukul** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Mrityunjai @ Mukul** of case **FIR No. 430/2022 U/s 325/341/506/34 IPC, P.S. Bhajan**



AS BILLIONS LACK SAFE WATER, A BOOMING GLOBAL INDUSTRY AND AI-DRIVEN DEMAND ARE TURNING A BASIC HUMAN NECESSITY INTO ONE OF THE WORLD’S FASTEST-GROWING COMMODITIES

AUTHOR



DIPANKAR DEY

The United Nations ‘World Water Development Report 2026: Water for All People – Equal Rights and Opportunities’, highlights how unequal access to water and sanitation services impacts health, education, livelihoods and safety. Today, 2.1 billion people still lack safely managed drinking water, and women and girls spend an estimated 250 million hours every day collecting water. Unfortunately, privately owned global water utility corporations now control this vital natural resource- essential for the survival of the planet Earth.

GLOBAL WATER INDUSTRY

Driven by increasing urbanisation, industrial use and the need for advanced water management solutions, the global water and wastewater treatment market size was valued at USD 372.39 billion in 2025 and is projected to grow from USD 400.32 billion in 2026 to USD 713.96 billion by 2034, exhibiting a CAGR of 7.50 per cent during the forecast period.

The water market is segmented by product types, its usages and geographic distribution. The segmentation by product types is: water treatment technologies, desalination plants and smart water management systems. Water treatment technologies lead the mater market by product type with the largest market share by value. Water market segmentation by application is: municipal water supply, industrial water use and agricultural water use. In this segment, the municipal water supply leads the global water market. Region-wise, the water market can be divided into the following segments.

- » North America dominated the water and wastewater treatment market with a market share of 38.20 per cent in 2025, driven by increasing adoption of smart water management systems, membrane filtration technologies, and a strong focus on water reuse. The U.S. market is projected to reach USD 138.93 billion by 2026.
- » The Asia Pacific market was valued at USD 140.12 billion in 2025, capturing 37.60 per cent of global revenue, and is estimated to reach USD 152.29 billion in 2026. China and India are witnessing substantial investments in wastewater infrastructure to address water pollution concerns. The Japan market is projected to reach USD 3.96 billion by 2026, the China market is projected to reach USD 99.8 billion by 2026, and the India market is projected to reach USD 23.3 billion by 2026. India has the 5th largest water and wastewater treatment market in

Drops of Inequality

54% OF INDIA FACES HIGH TO EXTREMELY HIGH WATER STRESS

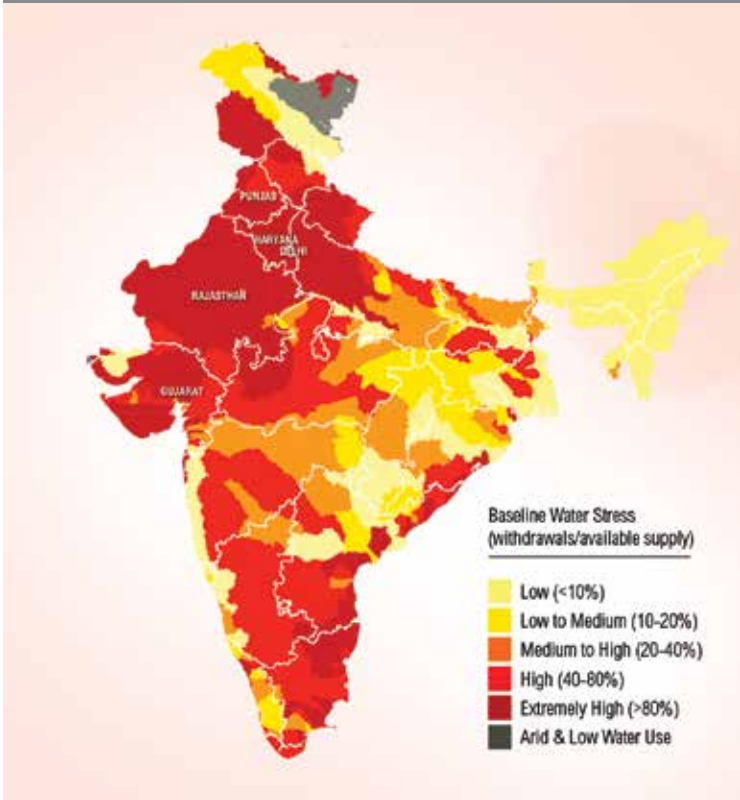


TABLE 1: A FEW MAJOR DESALINATION COMPANIES IN THE WORLD

NAME OF THE COMPANY	COUNTRY	MAJOR DESALINATION PLANTS
Acciona Agua	Spain	Madinah 3 WWTP (Saudi Arabia), Buraidah 2 WWTP, (Saudi Arabia)
Abengoa SA	Spain	Taweelah Desalination Plant (UAE), Jubail 3A (Saudi Arabia), Shuaibah (Saudi Arabia)
Doosan Heavy Industry & Construction	South Korea	Yanbu 4 -(Saudi Arabia), On June 27 that it signed a seawater desalination plant construction project with Sazeh Sazan, an Iranian company. The value of the contract is 220 billion won and the plant is to use reverse osmosis technology.
The IDE Technologies	Israel	Sorek I Desalination Plant (Israel), Hadera Desalination Plant (Israel), Tianjin Desalination Plant (China), Carlsbad Desalination Plant (San Diego County)
VA Tech Wabag	India	AL Ghubra Desalination Plant(Oman), Nemmeli Seawater Desalination Plant (India)
Veolia Water	France	Fujairah Desalination Plant (UAE), Umm AL Quwain IWP (UAE), Rabigh 3 (Saudi Arabia), Oman Sur (Oman)

the world, valued at approximately \$11 billion. It is expected to grow to over \$18 billion by 2026. With 18 per cent of the world's population but only 4 per cent of the world's water sources, India grapples with water scarcity in many regions.

- » Europe accounted for USD 60.78 billion in 2025, representing 16.30 per cent of the global market share, and is projected to reach USD 64.67 billion in 2026.
- » The UK market is projected to reach USD 11.09 billion by 2026, while the



is that AI-related chip manufacturing and power generation consume even more water than data centres. Taken together, these three sectors make up an “AI economy” whose demand for water is rising rapidly.

At present, the AI economy consumes 23 cubic kilometres of water a year. By 2050, this is predicted to more than double (up 129 per cent) to more than 54 cubic kilometres (roughly 14 trillion US gallons), according to new research by Global Water Intelligence and Xylem. In other words, our world needs to find an extra 31 cubic kilometres of water a year for the AI economy to run. That's enough to supply every human being on Earth with an extra 3,820 litres of freshwater a year.

GROWING MARKET FOR DESALINATION WATER PLANTS

The market for desalination water plants is growing very fast and is projected to grow at 9.5 per cent and reach the \$32 billion mark by 2025. Desalination plants turn saltwater from the oceans into freshwater for human use. Saudi Arabia is the global leader in water desalination, producing roughly 22 per cent of the world's desalinated water. The kingdom hosts the largest plants, including the Ras Al-Khair and Shuqaiq facilities. The Middle East overall leads with 60 per cent of global capacity, heavily relying on seawater reverse osmosis (SWRO) for water security. Saudi Arabia- the world's largest producer with over 30 major plants and massive expansion projects. UAE- operates high-capacity plants like Jebel Ali and Taweelah, with nearly 90 per cent of its drinking water derived from desalination. Israel- a technological leader, with plants like Sorek Desalination Plant providing a significant portion of national demand. In Israel, six desalination stations supply around 800 million cubic meters of water, thus meeting 70 per cent to 80 per cent of the country's potable water needs. A seventh station, located in the Western Galilee, is planned to come online in 2027 and provide an additional 100 million cubic meters.

WATER IN THE “AI ECONOMY”

One of the major drivers of the water industry is the rising demand for water in the “AI economy”. Data centres are often the most visible AI water consumers. Even with efficient cooling, a single hyperscale data centre (~130 megawatts) can use 171 million litres of water annually. But what is less visible

1) that receive scanty rainfall and are rich sources of seawater to conduct the desalination process.

Experts see a future where industrially useful minerals such as sodium chloride salt, magnesium and calcium are extracted from the seawater alongside clean water, and no highly-salty wastewater - known as brine. As focus shifts towards green investments, several oil and gas and utilities sector investments are becoming less attractive. Even as investors pull out of the largest energy companies for renewable alternatives, investors are looking to invest in the top desalination companies, and it is fast becoming one of the upcoming green investment channels to look out for.

DOMINANCE OF EUROPEAN AND US COMPANIES

Europe and USA-based major water utility companies dominate the global water industry (Table 2). Veolia SA and Suez SA –the two French companies were established in 1853 and 1880, respectively. Xylem Inc was established in 1911. Veolia, the oldest company, is the industry leader. A few Chinese companies, like Beijing Enterprises Water Group- a leading water utility service provider operating numerous projects and serving a large population and Beijing Capital Co Ltd.-a significant player in the Chinese municipal water market, are emerging players in this fast-growing industry.

As a result of increased urbanisation in 19th-century Europe, the traditional reliance on water from wells, water vendors or other sources was replaced by a centralised water supply system. This occurred in 1802 in Paris, 1808 in London and 1856 in Berlin. In New York, a major epidemic of yellow fever struck in 1795. The public blamed the poor quality of ‘tea water’ and filthy wells for this epidemic. Under public pressure, the city turned to the private sector to provide clean drinking water. Hence, the Manhattan Company, which later became the Chase Manhattan Bank, was formed to deliver water in the city.

During its first industrial revolution in the 16th century, London was unwilling to spend more on public works and therefore called on the private sector. By the 19th century, the water supply was concentrated in nine water companies.

In the aftermath of a major cholera outbreak in 1840, the water companies became regulated entities. They were required to supply continuous filtered piped water to residences. In 1902, with the Metropolis Water Act, the water entities were municipalised. In 1861, the share of private provision of water supply in larger towns was 60 per cent, which decreased over time, reaching 20 per cent in 1881 and only 10 per cent in 1901. During the period 1900-1974, the municipalities were in charge of the water supply, with the exception of 20 per cent of the population who were supplied by private water companies.

One of the main reasons why so many developing countries decide to involve the private sector in water and other infrastructure is the influence and persuasiveness of international donors, like the World Bank, UNDP, WTO, IMF, Bill Gates, Melinda Gates Foundation, et al, that support such policies. Since the early 1990s, the Bank has adopted a strong position in favour of privatised water. This was promoted through policy reports, support for joint initiatives (such as the Global Water Partnership and World Water Council) with water multinationals, and through loan conditionalities or policy-based lending, observes Naren Prasad, UNRISD.

Thanks to the global corporations, water has become a fast-growing economic commodity over the last two centuries.

TABLE 2: THE 10 MAJOR GLOBAL WATER UTILITY AND TREATMENT COMPANIES IN 2025

NAME OF THE COMPANY	COUNTRY	REVENUE	TYPE OF SERVICE
Veolia Environment SA	France	€44.396 billion (2025)	A global leader in water management, desalination, and waste services
Suez SA	France	€9.2 billion (2024)	A major operator serving millions with drinking water and sanitation services
Kerima	Finland	€2.8 billion (2025)	The safe and sustainable way to clean water through waste water treatment
American Water Works Company, Inc.	USA	\$5.14 billion (2025)	The largest publicly traded water utility in the United States
Xylem Inc	USA	\$8.6 billion (2024)	A leading water technology company providing solutions for water treatment and infrastructure
Ecotab Inc	USA	\$16.1 billion (2025)	Known for its water treatment technologies and sustainability solutions
Acciona Agua	Spain	€1.39 billion (2025)	A major global player in desalination and water treatment services
3M Water Treatment Systems	USA	\$6.0 (2025)	Residential water solutions
Danaher Corporation	USA	\$23.9 billion (2024)	Its “Water Quality” platform is a market leader providing instruments for water analysis and treatment.
United Utilities Group PLC	UK	£2.15 billion (2025)	A major provider of water and sewage services in the UK

SOURCE: COMPILED BY THE AUTHOR FROM COMPANY WEBSITES AND INDUSTRY PUBLICATIONS

WELLNESS

BEYOND MOOD SWINGS



Bipolar disorder is more than mood swings—it is a cyclical mental health condition requiring early recognition, structured treatment and sustained family support

AUTHOR



ERA DUTTA

My father is 52, a successful businessman, and someone we've always looked up to. But over the last few years, we've noticed patterns we don't understand. There are phases where he barely sleeps, takes big financial risks, starts multiple projects, talks excessively, and seems unusually confident—almost unlike himself. He becomes irritable if questioned. Then, after a few weeks, he crashes. He withdraws, avoids work, loses interest in everything, and seems deeply low and fatigued. A psychiatrist has diagnosed him with bipolar disorder. What does this mean? How do we help him?

World Bipolar Day, observed on March 30, exists for exactly these situations—to improve recognition and reduce stigma around a condition often misunderstood as “just mood swings.”

Let's break this down. The first phase you describe is mania or hypomania. During this period, your father appears energised, productive, and driven. He may sleep very little, take on ambitious plans, spend impulsively, and make high-stakes decisions with unusual confidence. To others, this can look like peak performance. Clinically, however, it reflects a state of elevated mood and dysregulated energy.

Common features of mania include a reduced need for sleep without fatigue, racing thoughts, pressured speech, increased goal-directed activity, and risk-taking behaviour. Irritability when questioned is also typical. While this phase may seem productive initially, it is often unsustainable and followed by consequences—financial strain, interpersonal conflict, or poor decision-making.

This is followed by the second phase: the depressive crash. Here, your father becomes withdrawn, fatigued, and disinterested. This is not simple burnout. It aligns with a depressive episode marked by persistent low mood, loss of interest, slowed thinking, and feelings of hopelessness.

What defines Bipolar disorder is this cyclical shift between elevated and depressed states, not isolated mood changes.

WHY DOES THIS HAPPEN?

Bipolar disorder is a biological condition with genetic and neurochemical underpinnings. The brain's systems regulating mood, sleep, and energy become unsta-

ble. Triggers such as sleep disruption, stress, or major life events can precipitate episodes, but the underlying vulnerability remains.

It affects roughly 1-2 per cent of the population and presents in different forms:

- » Bipolar I involves full manic episodes;
- » Bipolar II involves hypomania with depression;
- » Cyclothymia involves milder but chronic fluctuations over two years or more.

A key reason bipolar disorder is often missed, especially in adults, is that mania is misread as personality or success. Families usually seek help during depression, while the earlier “high” phase goes unnoticed. Many individuals are initially treated for depression alone, delaying accurate diagnosis.

SO WHAT CAN YOU DO AS A FAMILY?

Start with concern, not confrontation. Instead of labelling every behaviour, say: “We've noticed these changes and we're worried about you.” Encourage continued psychiatric care, as diagnosis and treatment are ongoing processes.

Treatment is effective but structured.

BIPOLAR DISORDER is marked by alternating phases of mania and depression, often mistaken for personality traits or stress

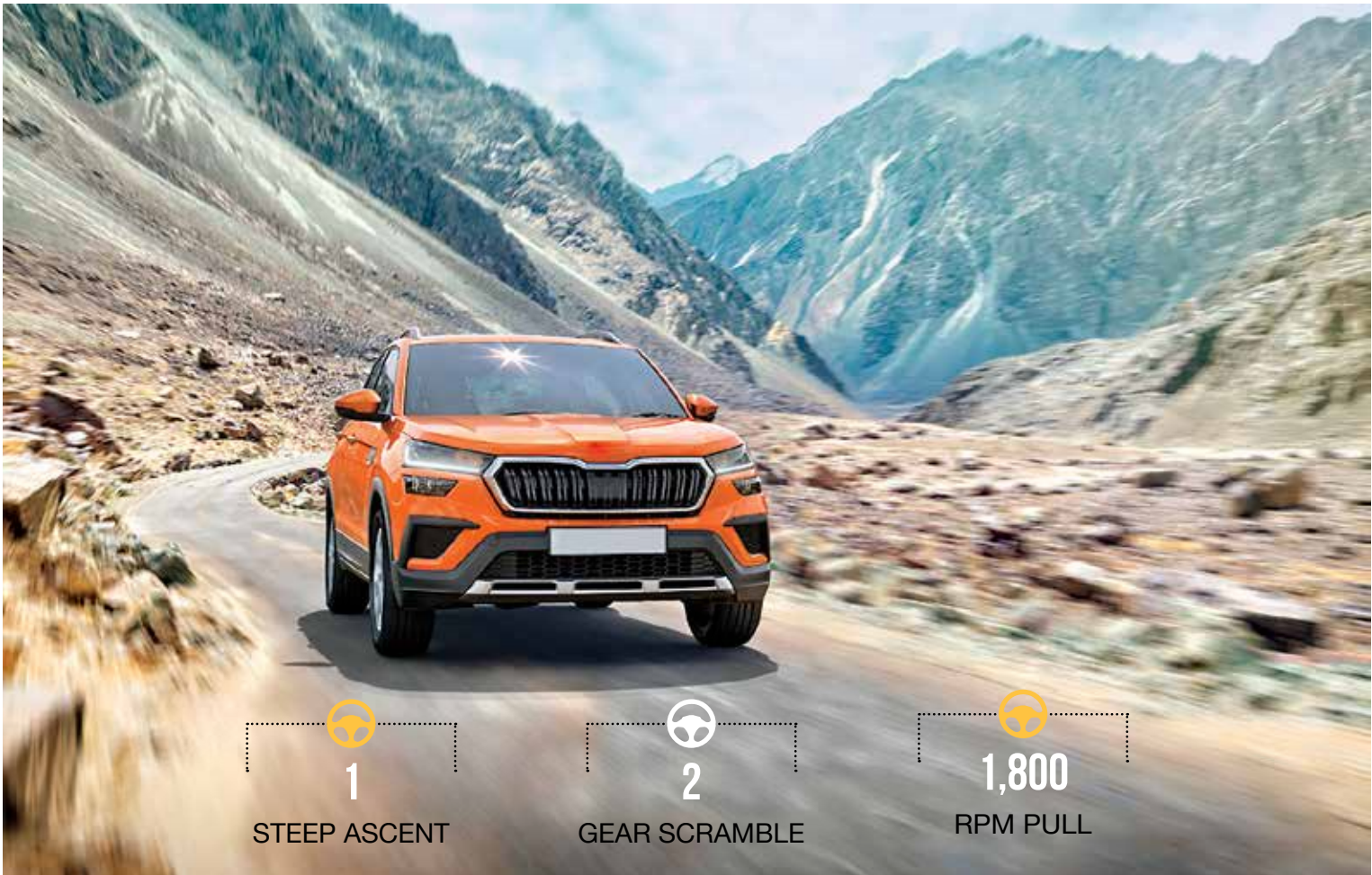
Medication is essential—typically mood stabilisers and, in some cases, antipsychotics. Therapy, such as Cognitive Behavioural Therapy and Interpersonal Social Rhythm Therapy, helps regulate routines and identify triggers.

Equally important is routine stability. Fixed sleep schedules, predictable daily patterns, and avoiding sudden lifestyle changes are critical. In bipolar disorder, sleep is a powerful regulator. Families can also watch for early warning signs. Before mania, there may be reduced sleep, increased activity, or impulsive decisions. Before depression, withdrawal, fatigue, and loss of interest appear. Recognising these early helps prevent escalation.

World Bipolar Day matters because too many families spend years confused, attributing these changes to stress or personality. Bipolar disorder is not a flaw. It is a treatable medical condition. Your father is not “changing as a person”—he is experiencing episodic shifts in brain function. With the right treatment and consistent support, stability is achievable.

The goal is not to suppress who he is, but to help him remain consistently himself—without the extremes taking over.

PUBLIC FIGURES like Stephen Fry, Demi Lovato, Carrie Fisher and Kanye West have helped bring visibility to bipolar disorder. Films like *Silver Linings Playbook* and *Infinitely Polar Bear* also depict its lived realities.



Lessons from India's HILL CLIMB



Climbing mountain roads teaches a lesson every driver learns – that BHP figures matter far less than torque, balance, mechanical capability and driver prowess

AUTHOR



RAJEEV NARAYAN

India's mountain roads have a peculiar sense of timing, and they can be mighty humbling. They often make the proudest of car-owners face a belittling reality – that in a crunch, the performance specs in the glossy showroom brochure are mere numbers on a piece of shiny paper. It usually happens on a steep incline. The road narrows, the engine note deepens, the car ahead suddenly slows to a crawl and gravity tugs. The driver ahead slams on the gas, expecting a burst of speed. Instead, his car hesitates, downshifts, strains... and then it stalls.

Welcome to the hill climb, the place where the postulates of automotive engineering meet the laws of physics. For generations of drivers, mountain roads – from the misty bends of Himachal Pradesh to the winding ghats of Maharashtra – have been an earthy proving ground for cars. Horsepower figures become less important and the fundamentals take over: torque, gearing, traction and balance. It is on these climbs that the true character of man and machine reveals itself.

POWER VS TORQUE

In car advertisements, horsepower gets the spotlight. BHP sounds dramatic and impressive on paper, bespeaking speed and performance. But on steep hills, torque takes the lead role. Torque is the grunt, the brute power that an engine produces, the mechanical strength that moves the wheels against resistance. When a car climbs, it is not merely moving forward; it is lifting its own mass against gravity. That requires visceral force and raw power, not mere speed.

A torquey car pulls steadily uphill without repeated gear-shifts – the

engine is calm; the vehicle moves with authority and the wheels barely notice the gradient. Conversely, cars with weak torque are forced to rely on high engine revs to maintain momentum. Drivers press harder on the gas, downshift more often, but still struggle to maintain speed on particularly steep sections.

This is where diesel engines have earned a loyal following among drivers who often travel on hilly terrain. Diesel engines produce higher torque at lower revs, allowing the vehicle to climb with minimal effort. Petrol engines have become more capable in recent years, especially with turbochargers, but the principle remains the same. Climbing hills is about force, not flair.

THE GHAT LESSON

India's ghat roads offer a practical classroom in automotive physics. Take a typical mountain ascent; a series of hairpin bends lined up circuitously on a hill. Each corner forces the driver to slow consciously before climbing again. The engine must repeatedly pull the vehicle out of low-speed turns while coping with steep gradients.

This is where gearing becomes critical. A well-matched gearbox allows the engine to stay within its most effective power band. The driver can select a gear that provides both pulling power and smooth acceleration without overworking the engine. Manual transmissions often shine in such environments because they allow drivers to control gear selection precisely.

But modern auto gearboxes, especially torque converters and dual-clutch systems, have also become remarkable at predicting climbs and holding the correct gear. In fact, some new vehicles even feature dedicated ‘hill modes’ designed to manage steep ascents efficiently.

Technology is learning the language of the *pahaad*.

WEIGHT AND BALANCE

There is another car factor that becomes obvious during hill climbs. Weight. Today's cars are heavier. Larger bodies, safety equipment, bigger wheels and luxury features have added mass. While powerful engines compensate for this weight

on highways, steep inclines expose the penalty. A heavier vehicle requires more torque to climb the same hill. This partly explains why smaller, lighter vehicles often feel surprisingly capable on mountain roads despite modest power outputs. Their engines may be smaller, but they have to move less mass uphill. The Suzuki Alto is a highly visible example. Hill locals don't call it ‘Lord Alto’ for nothing.

Vehicle balance plays a role too. A well-poised chassis distributes weight evenly across all four wheels, maintaining traction even when the road is uneven or slippery. Poorly balanced cars struggle for grip, particularly on tight inclines or loose surfaces. All-wheel-drive systems, often associated with SUVs, improve climbing ability by providing power to multiple wheels rather than relying solely on the front or rear axle. But even sans advanced drivetrains, engineering can make a difference.

ON STEEP AND CURVACEOUS HILL ROADS, BHP IS REDUCED TO BEING A PAPER TIGER. Gearing, instinct AND LADY LUCK DETERMINE WHICH VEHICLES WILL TRULY CLIMB

WHAT OF DRIVER ABILITY?

For all the engineering genius packed into modern vehicles, the hill climb still demands skill from the driver. Careful throttle inputs are key. Abrupt bursts of power can break traction, especially on wet or dusty hill roads. Maintaining momentum through corners becomes a delicate balancing act between speed and control. Experienced drivers learn to read the road ahead – anticipating bends, choosing gears early and allowing the engine to pull steadily rather than forcing it to surge.

Hill starts also reveal a driver's finesse. On steep gradients, rolling

back even a bit can be unnerving. Modern cars often feature hill-start assist systems that briefly hold the brakes as the driver transitions to the accelerator, but seasoned drivers rely more on instinct and coordination. Hill driving is not just about machinery; it is about rhythm.

MADNESS FOR SUVs

India's love affair with SUVs has added an interesting twist to the hill-climb equation. SUVs offer higher ground clearance, stronger suspension and more powerful engines, qualities that make them ideal for rugged terrain. Their upright stance and commanding view inspire confidence on winding roads. But SUVs are also heavier and taller than traditional cars. Thus, the extra weight has to be managed tidily on steep inclines and tight corners.

Auto firms have reacted by designing engines with low-end torque and refined transmissions to handle climbing loads. The result is a modern SUV that feels remarkably comfortable in the crisp hilly air. But the hills have the final say. Even the most capable car has to respect the laws of gravity and traction.

THE IMMORTAL CLIMB

This aspect may be why hill driving holds such enduring appeal. There is something elemental about the experience – engine pulling steadily, gears working in harmony, roads curling upward through forests and mist. Every climb becomes a mechanical love-fest between driver, machine and terrain. In this dialogue, marketing spiel fades away. What remains is a moot question – can the car pull itself?

In an era where automotive conversations often hinge on touchscreen sizes and digital features, the hill climb reminds us of the fundamentals. Torque, balance, gearing and control. They are what matter. For drivers who live with mountains that rise sharply from the plains and highways that suddenly twist into ghats, the lesson is endless. Because around the next bend, gravity is again waiting.

History vs Interpretation

The debate over whether Hinduism was “invented” in the 19th century opens larger questions about identity, continuity, memory and civilisational self-awareness

SHASHI RANJAN KUMAR

Some historians may scoff at the very term ‘Hindu civilisation’, for they contend that Hinduism itself is an invention or a construction of the 19th century, and that Hindus themselves were not aware of their distinctive religious identity in any meaningful sense before this. However, there is much disagreement among them on who invented Hinduism. While some credit this invention wholly to British scholars and administrators, others share it with Indian nationalists and communalists, and a few attribute it solely to Indians. When it comes to what exactly is meant by the ‘invention of Hinduism’, the question can be addressed in two ways. Superficially, it means the construction of the word ‘Hinduism’ itself, which starts appearing in the early 19th century, more precisely in 1816, in Ram Mohan Roy’s works. But this date has been pushed back recently to 1787 by Asko Parpola, who credits this neologism to Charles Grant, an East India Company merchant and an evangelical Christian. No matter when exactly the word first appeared, it is undeniable that it gained currency only in the second quarter of the 19th century, mostly in books by British authors. So, in that limited sense, it is indeed correct to say that Hinduism was invented in the 19th century. More substantively, however, what is implied by the term ‘invention of Hinduism’ is that a single conceptual category called ‘Hinduism’ was invented and foisted upon a heterogeneous collection of sects, doctrines and customs that neither had anything in common, nor were any such commonalities recognised by the Hindus themselves.

The casual sense of the term is so trivial that it does not merit refutation, for to claim that an idea or a concept does not exist until it is given a name is an indefensible position—it is like saying that Pythagorean triplets did not exist before they were so named. The substantive meaning of the term can be better understood by asking two related questions: Did the various sects, doctrines, and customs, which we now call Hinduism, have

anything in common? If yes, did the followers of these heterogeneous sects perceive these commonalities?

The concepts of *karma*, *punarjanma*, *samsara*, *moksha*, etc., are shared by all sects, including heterodox Buddhists and Jains.

All schools of philosophy, including the four heterodox schools, operate within the same epistemological framework of *pramanas*. The cyclic conception of time, as also the broader cosmology, is common to all. Even though a deity may belong to a particular sect, its followers are not prevented from worshipping other deities. Rather, the difference lies in the degree of emphasis given to the principal deity. What appears as a motley collection of endless diversity has a fundamental essence, and if scholars, of all people, fail to notice it, one can only be infuriatingly surprised.

Agamadambara is a philosophical play written by Jayanta Bhatta, a minister in the court of Shankaravarman of Kashmir (r. c. 883–902). The central character of the play, Shankarshana, a recently graduated young Mimamsa philosopher in the capital city of Srinagara, considers it his sacred duty not to rest until opponents of the Vedas are utterly defeated—of course, only through reason. The first of such debates happens with a Buddhist scholar, Dharmottara, according to the methods, standards, and decorum laid down by the observers. Shankarshana first gives a brief summary of the Buddhist tenets, which is then approved by Dharmottara. Thereafter, Shankarshana systematically refutes the Buddhist doctrines of *kshanabhangavada* (momentariness) and *vijnanavada* (consciousness-only). Subsequently, he takes on a *Jaina*, a *Charvaka*, and the adherents of *Agamas*, especially the *Pancharatra Agama*. But the play ends on a rather conciliatory note, with a peroration by Dhairyarashi, an umpire appointed by the queen to adjudicate the final debate: “This one God, by His own free will, takes manifold forms as Pasupati, Kapila, Visnu, Sankarsana, Jina, Buddha, and Manu, and teaches the different *Agamas*.” He goes even further and proclaims complete equality among all sects: “If Vaidikas are to deny the continuity of the other traditions



or attribute motives to them, the same criticisms, it may be pointed out, have been brought against the Vedas by the *Nastikas* and *Carvakas*.” Shankarshana, instead of demurring, applauds him for his penetrative analysis, eloquence, and mastery over the *Shastras*. Two things are noteworthy: first, the methods of *vada* (debate)—the distinctive tradition of first stating the position of the opponent—apply equally to all sects, including the unorthodox; second, the dramatis personae return to their *svabhava* after some bitter intellectual wranglings—that the truth is one, but wise people call it by various names.

Whether the Hindus possessed a self-conscious religious identity before the 19th century is a more complex question. Denialists place reliance on the fact that the word ‘Hindu’ was used in an ethno-geographical sense, beginning with the inscriptions of Darius I, from the 6th century BCE. Lorenzen argues that if the word ‘Hindu’ had been purely an ethno-geographical term right up to the 19th century, then India-born descendants of foreign

Muslims, or at least native converts to Islam, should have been called ‘Hindus’ or ‘Hindu Muslims’. But any evidence of this is wholly absent.

Denialists also argue that Sanskrit sources identify foreign invaders by names such as *tajika*, *turushka*, *mlchchha*, *yavana*, *hammira*, *shaka*, etc., and not by their religion. Brajadulal Chattopadhyaya gives us a list of Sanskrit sources between the 8th and the 17th centuries, which contains various terms used for Muslims, but ‘*musalamana*’ has been used only once in about 70 instances to refer to them. I will have something interesting to say later on why Muslims were referred to in such an oblique manner in Sanskrit sources. At this point, it is sufficient to say that all epithets used for Muslims had negative connotations, and sometimes these terms conveyed the sense of an impending

apocalypse. However, the evidence from vernacular literature is quite unambiguous and abundant, and I need only summon the erudition of Lorenzen: the bulk of this evidence takes the form of texts composed by popular religious poet-singers of North India, most of them members of non-Brahmin castes. This literature does precisely what Sanskrit literature refuses to do: it establishes a Hindu religious identity through a process of mutual self-definition with a contrasting Muslim Other. In practice, there can be no Hindu identity unless this is defined by contrast against such an Other. Without the Muslim (or some other non-Hindu), Hindus can only be Vaishnavas, Saivas, Smartas, or the like. The presence of the Other is a necessary prerequisite for an active recognition of what the different Hindu sects and schools hold in common.

To buttress his assertion, Lorenzen presents a few examples, but for the sake of brevity, I shall reproduce only one, which is an extract from Kirtilata, a historical romance of Vidyapati, composed in the early 15th century.

Lorenzen argues that the conjoining of the word ‘dhamme’ with ‘hindu’ and ‘turake’ provides us with the closest vernacular equivalence of the terms ‘religion of the Hindus’ and ‘religion of the Muslims’.

Moreover, the heightened sense of contrastive awareness in the passage is impossible to ignore. Also, this challenges the assertion that “the term ‘Hindu’ as referring to a religion is initially absent in the vocabulary of Indian languages and only slowly gains currency.” The overwhelming evidence from vernacular literature makes a compelling case to accept his proposition that “the often antagonistic modern Hindu and Muslim identities, both individual and communitarian, arose out

of political and religious conflicts during the historical periods of the Delhi Sultanate, the Mughal Empire, and the regional Sultanates.” There indeed existed a distinct way of life with a common operating system that got crystallised only after an encounter with the Other, and although this has been held by critics as its incapacity to express itself purely in an intrinsic manner, I find this quite in tune with the natural order of things. The ethno-geographical sense of being a Hindu was crystallised soon after coming into contact with a different ethnographical entity. Similarly, the religious sense of being a Hindu was precipitated by the arrival of Islam. Where does our South Asian identity find expression, if not in distant geographies like the UK and the US? If you randomly ask anyone in an international gathering about their identity, they will surely refer to their nationality; hardly anyone will claim to belong to the world or to planet Earth. This, however, might change if an alien civilisation from an exoplanet were to invade the Earth. The latent shared sense of humanity would then manifest to counter the threat.

At any rate, the proponents of the ‘invention of Hinduism’ thesis are obliged to explain why Hindus enthusiastically embraced the imposition of a wholly artificial construct on what ostensibly was a heterogeneous collection of sects, doctrines, and customs, if no unifying feature was already extant. I am firmly on the side of those who think that the collective religious identity of the Hindus had been lying dormant for long, and that it was catalysed by the arrival of Islam in the subcontinent, and not in the 19th century, as the opponents claim.

My only point of departure from Lorenzen is in the antiquity of Hinduism. While he sees it taking shape in the early Puranas, roughly c. 300–600 CE—although, in all fairness, it ought to be said that he concedes the point about its continuity with the earlier Vedic religion—I see Hinduism as a living and constantly evolving tradition from the very dawn of civilization, and any attempt to pronounce a specific date, or even a period, for its origin would be an unwelcome arrogation.

THE QUESTION IS NOT WHEN “Hinduism” APPEARED, BUT WHETHER ITS TRADITIONS ALREADY SHARED A PHILOSOPHICAL AND CIVILISATIONAL CORE

Books

Tapestry of Dream & Memory

Easterine Kire’s *The Sky Husband* captures fragile human emotions through stories where dreams, spirits and memory shape destinies across time

AUTHOR



YAUVANIKA CHOPRA

God speaks to us through our dreams, says the wise woman Hami. Her neighbour Mimi has learned this truth, and it passed down in turn to her daughter Aniya. When Aniya - lovely, young, wealthy - begins to have a recurring dream about the man she is going to marry, it is Hami in whom she confides. And Hami - elder, experienced, elemental - ensures that the knowledge encoded in the dream can find realisation in their reality.

The titular story of Easterine Kire’s *The Sky Husband* is as expansive and poetic as the other seven short stories in this volume by an author whose craft is finely attuned at this height of her acclaimed career. Chan, the protagonist of “Chan and the Blue Forest”, does not dream — because he is lulled into long carefree sleeps in the arms of a beautiful forest spirit who has enchanted him away from his family. The ‘magical realism’ of this tale is narrated by an authorial stand-in, Noni, who recounts it from an interaction with a Manipuri student at JNU’s School of Social Sciences, where she has delivered a talk about “writing from the heart, writing what you love, believe in and care for, and not writing to fulfil people’s expectations.” But although Noni believes in this message, and although she goes on to meet Chan herself (she is struck by how extraordinary he looks when his face catches the light), his truth does seem unbelievable. “Who would believe me if I tried to share this story? I couldn’t think of anyone in my group of acquaintances and friends who would believe such things were still happening. My publisher would



give a listen and remark, ‘Oh, that’s very good fantasy stuff. Why don’t you write a novella about that?’”

In *The Tracker*, Ashi doesn’t have time to dream either. In the present day, when the story begins, she is an underappreciated wife in her sixties. In 1960, where the story travels, she was a new recruit of the Naga Army who became an invaluable asset for her keen sense of smell which could identify various animal scents and therefore ease out hunting. Theirs was an itinerant army which never stayed in the same place two nights in a row and never had any time to rest.

‘Cherry Blossoms in April’ also depicts the political history of the Nagas. In 1944 Kohima, which the Japanese occupy upon



ONE MUST MAKE SPECIAL MENTION OF A *book cover* WHICH DOES FULL JUSTICE TO THE BEAUTY OF THE WORDS INSIDE IT

promises of liberation from the British, love blooms between a captain and a local. To Sanuo, Akio is her sky husband. The chasm of language is erased through expression. “How many moments and hours and days did they have together? They were absorbed in each other, transcending speech, using only hand movements to tell each other their secrets and make each other happy. These are never the memories that remain and comfort. They are too fragile. Perhaps we were never meant to love on earth. The finest love stories always end in death or parting. Perhaps we overreach ourselves when we love.”

If *‘Sometimes Life’* presents the soft romantic dream of two lovers named Bani

and Liam reuniting after a fateful misunderstanding which caused a 30-year-long silence, its partner in *‘Bani’s Story II’* is “a living nightmare” for its protagonists. There is a fateful error again — but one which results in a life taken too soon, and the devastation left behind for all those who survived. *‘Dodili Vainilo’* is about suffering too: dreams erased because rest itself is impossible: “A persistent darkness fuelled the silent battle between light and gloom, truth and reality. An inky blackness unrelieved by starlight. Shula had never known such despondence before... And as she lay there, self-accusation entered in. She deserved to be deserted. The depths of despair that gripped her were indescribable.” But the title is an indication of love’s triumph after all. The beloved is a loving shepherd among the lilies, and can be relied upon for light.

‘How All Love Stories Should End’ is a final confirmation of cathartic destiny. The author returns as narrator for Uncle Ben and Aunt Nima (perhaps Rev. Dr I. Ben Wati and Nirmala Mahanty), who lived 60 years together before dying 16 days apart. Romeo and Juliet were given a contrived ending by Shakespeare: “... even the cleverest playwright surely could not have written an ending as beautiful and harmonious as that of Uncle Ben and Aunt Nima... Their spirits, briefly apart for some days, are now reunited beyond all fear of parting. Could any love story come up with a better ending than this one designed by the master storyteller?”

This is a book by a master storyteller.

A rich tapestry of spiritual traditions extends as the bedrock and firmament of knowledge. Insights on character have been honed over a lifetime of observation. Gentle and profound, but fundamentally resistant to simplistic categorisation, Kire’s writing sometimes feels like a vivid dream diary recorded for posterity. She is not writing fantasy, and is averse to terms like ‘magical realism’ because they fail to adequately convey the luminous literary imagination she inherited from her elders, which she has in turn left for us as alternate ways of seeing.

One must make special mention of a book cover which does full justice to the beauty of the words inside it: the cover illustration by Ogin Nayam is stunning, and Aakriti Khurana’s design locates it in an elegant continuation of waves across the back. It is evocative and mystical and stays with the reader.

God speaks to us through what we receive in chance encounters with art, music, trees, animals, strangers, friends, family — books. There is much we cannot and will never understand, but fleeting moments of clarity can serve as visions to overarching patterns which transcend time. The titular protagonist in Lakshmi Priya Devi’s recent BAFTA-winning film is a Manipuri boy who remembers to pray to God when he needs a favour and then proceeds in a sweet imitation of what he has seen his mother do. Our Gods will continue to vary, as will the ways in which we understand their messages. God will continue to speak to us, as Kire demonstrates, through the magic and mundanity of life itself.



Easterine Kire



AUTHOR



VINOD KUMAR

Chile's Colourful Coastal Secret

Perched on steep hills above the Pacific, Valparaíso is one of those bohemian cities that reveals itself through murals, streets and old funiculars

Most travellers heading to Chile instinctively think of Santiago or the dramatic landscapes of Patagonia. Guidebooks and travel blogs often reinforce that instinct, pushing visitors toward glaciers, national parks and the capital's urban pulse. Yet just a couple of hours from Santiago lies a city that feels far more eccentric, colourful and unpredictable than anything I expected from Chile. Valparaíso, perched along the Pacific coast, is less a destination you neatly explore and more a place you slowly unravel.

My journey to Valparaíso began on a grey morning bus ride from Santiago. The highway rolled through dry hills before the Pacific suddenly appeared, wide and steel-blue under a shifting sky. As the bus descended toward the port, the city revealed itself in layers. Houses clung to steep hillsides like bright Lego blocks scattered across the landscape. Yellow, turquoise, rust-red and pastel pink buildings stacked on top of one another as if gravity were merely a suggestion. It felt less like arriving in a city and more like walking into an enormous painting.

The bus terminal itself was unremarkable, but stepping outside, I sensed immediately that Valparaíso moves to its own rhythm. Port workers walked past carrying toolboxes, old trolleybuses rattled along the streets, and the smell of the sea drifted through the air. My small hotel sat somewhere up in the hills of Cerro Alegre, one of the neighbourhoods that travellers usually gravitate toward. Getting there meant climbing, and lots of it.

Valparaíso is a city built on hills—forty-two of them, locals like to remind visitors. To navigate the slopes, the city relies on old funicular lifts known as ascensores. Many date back more than a century, and riding one feels like stepping into a mechanical relic stubbornly refusing to retire. I boarded the Ascensor Reina Victoria, a wooden carriage that creaked as it began its slow climb. A middle-aged man standing beside me, clearly amused by my curiosity, explained that these lifts were once the lifeline of the city. “Without them,” he said, gesturing toward the steep streets outside, “nobody would reach home.”

At the top of the hill, Valparaíso opened up in a way that immediately made the climb worthwhile. Narrow

streets twisted between houses painted in wild colours. Murals covered almost every available wall. Some were political, others abstract, and many simply joyful explosions of colour. In Valparaíso, street art isn't decoration—

it is identity. Walking through the neighbourhood felt like moving through an outdoor gallery curated by the city itself.

Later that afternoon, I wandered down toward the port, following

staircases that seemed to appear out of nowhere. At one point I paused beside a small grocery shop where an elderly woman sat watching the street. She asked where I was from, and when I told her India, she smiled warmly and said something in Spanish that I only half understood. Eventually she gestured toward the hills and the sea below and simply said, “Valparaíso es extraño, pero hermoso.” Strange, but beautiful. It was probably the most accurate description of the city I heard during the entire trip.

Historically, Valparaíso was once one of the most important ports in the world. Before the Panama Canal opened in 1914, ships travelling between the Atlantic and Pacific oceans had little choice but to sail around South America's Cape Horn. Valparaíso became a natural stopover, attracting traders, sailors and migrants from Europe and beyond. The city grew wealthy during that era, and traces of its former prosperity still linger in the faded elegance of old buildings near the harbour. Yet when global

shipping routes changed, Valparaíso's fortunes faded too. What remained was a city that carried its history lightly, almost casually.

One evening I found myself in a small bar overlooking the harbour. The bartender poured a glass of Chilean Carménère and pointed toward the dark silhouettes of cargo ships anchored offshore. “The port never sleeps,” he said. A group of university students nearby were debating politics with theatrical intensity, occasionally glancing at the television mounted above the counter. News channels spoke about conflicts unfolding in distant parts of the world—wars that felt both remote and strangely connected to global shipping and trade. Listening to those conversations while watching the quiet movement of ships across the water gave the evening an unexpected sense of perspective. Ports have always been places where local life intersects with global events.

The next morning I decided to explore more of the hills. Cerro Concepción, just a short walk from Cerro Alegre, offered another maze of streets, viewpoints and murals. At one overlook, the entire city stretched below me: rows of houses tumbling toward the ocean, cranes standing tall along the harbour and the Pacific fading into the horizon. A young couple nearby were taking photographs, occasionally laughing as the wind tugged at their jackets. I sat there for nearly half an hour doing nothing in particular—just watching the city breathe.

Valparaíso rewards exactly that kind of unstructured wandering. Unlike cities where attractions are neatly listed on a map, here the most memorable moments appear unexpectedly. A staircase painted like a giant piano keyboard. A cat sleeping on a windowsill beside a mural of Pablo Neruda. A musician playing guitar in a quiet plaza while tourists drift past. Every corner seems to hold a small surprise.

One afternoon I followed a steep path down toward the harbour district, where the city feels slightly rougher around the edges. Old warehouses lined the waterfront, and fishermen repaired nets beside small boats rocking gently in the tide. A young man selling empanadas from a street cart insisted I try one fresh from the pan. The pastry was hot, filled with seafood and onions, and eaten while standing beside the Pacific it tasted somehow better than any restaurant meal.

Valparaíso can be chaotic at times. Streets twist unpredictably, directions become confusing, and the hills guarantee that your legs will feel the journey by evening. Yet those imperfections are exactly what give the city its character. It refuses to present itself as a polished postcard.

On my final evening I climbed one last staircase back toward Cerro Alegre. The sun was beginning to set, casting long shadows across the hillsides. Houses glowed softly in shades of orange and pink as the Pacific turned silver in the fading light. Somewhere below, a ship's horn echoed through the harbour.

Standing there, I realised that Valparaíso does not try to impress in the way grand capitals often do. Instead, it reveals itself slowly through conversations, colours and small encounters. It is a city where history, art and everyday life spill into the streets with unapologetic energy.

When I boarded the bus back to Santiago the next morning, the hills gradually disappeared from view. Yet the memory of Valparaíso stayed vivid—the murals, the funicular rides, the sea breeze and the quiet understanding that some cities are best appreciated not through monuments, but through the stories they quietly tell.



GASTRONOMY

MUSHROOM BEAN BURRITO



INGREDIENTS

- » Large flour tortillas — 4
- » Mushrooms (sliced) — 200 g
- » Cooked kidney beans — 150 g
- » Onion (finely chopped) — 1 medium
- » Garlic (minced) — 2 cloves
- » Olive oil — 2 tbsp
- » Tomato (chopped) — 1 medium
- » Red chilli flakes — ½ tsp
- » Ground cumin — ½ tsp
- » Salt — to taste
- » Black pepper — to taste
- » Cooked rice — 1 cup
- » Cheddar cheese (grated) — ½ cup
- » Fresh coriander (chopped) — 2 tbsp
- » Lime juice — 1 tbsp
- » Sour cream or yogurt — 3 tbsp

DIRECTIONS

Heat olive oil in a wide skillet over medium heat. Add the chopped onion and sauté until it softens and turns lightly golden. Stir in the minced garlic and cook briefly until fragrant. Add the sliced mushrooms and cook them for several minutes, stirring occasionally, until they release their moisture and begin to brown. Mushrooms shrink considerably as they cook, and allowing them to brown slightly helps deepen their flavour. Next, add the chopped tomatoes, cooked kidney beans, chilli flakes and ground cumin. Season with salt and freshly ground black pepper. Cook the mixture for another three to four minutes, stirring occasionally so the flavours combine well. The filling should be moist but not watery. Stir in the cooked rice and mix everything gently so the grains absorb the spices and juices from the mushrooms and beans. Finish by adding chopped coriander and a squeeze of lime juice to brighten the flavour. Warm the tortillas briefly in a dry pan or microwave so they become soft and pliable. Place a generous portion of the mushroom filling along the centre of each tortilla. Sprinkle grated cheddar cheese over the filling and add a small spoonful of sour cream or yogurt for extra richness. Fold the sides of the tortilla inward and roll it tightly from the bottom to form a burrito. If desired, place the rolled burritos back in the pan for a minute so the outside becomes lightly toasted and the cheese melts slightly. Serve warm with extra lime wedges or a simple salsa on the side.



TIP



Cook mushrooms until browned before adding other ingredients; this prevents soggy filling and enhances the burrito's savoury flavour.



A CITY OF FORTY-TWO HILLS

Located on Chile's Pacific coast about 115 km from Santiago, Valparaíso is one of the country's most distinctive port cities. Built across 42 steep hills, it is known for colourful houses, murals and historic funicular lifts called ascensores. Once a vital global shipping hub before the Panama Canal opened in 1914, the city today blends maritime heritage with a vibrant artistic culture.

'DIDN'T KNOW THAT MY CHARACTER WAS **BADE SAHAB**'

Danish Iqbal talked about playing Dawood Ibrahim in 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge'

SUPRIYA SOGLE

The mystery around who is Bade Sahab and who is playing the shadowy character had gripped audiences since they saw Aditya Dhar's 'Dhurandhar' and its follow-up 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' has answered - the man is none other than underworld don Dawood Ibrahim, portrayed by actor Danish Iqbal.

The revelation came as a surprise even to the actor himself, who said even though he knew about his role of Ibrahim, the man held responsible for the 1993 Mumbai serial bomb blasts and numerous other terror incidents in India, but was never told that the character was actually Bade Sahab.

"I got my Eidi a little early... I knew that I was playing Dawood Ibrahim in this film, but I didn't know that Dawood Ibrahim was 'Bade Sahab' to be very honest. So, I kept wondering who Bade Sahab could be. But when only a few weeks were left before the film's release, somewhere I started to feel that maybe Dawood Ibrahim's character itself could be Bade Sahab," he told PTI in an interview.

In 'Dhurandhar', Bade Sahab was the unseen but omnipresent force - controlling Lyari's crime lords, ISI handlers, senior police officers and political fixers, while remaining entirely off-screen.

Since speculation around who Bade Sahab truly was had been rife on and offline, with names like Salman

Khan and Emraan Hashmi doing the rounds. "People were really interested in knowing who is going to play Bade Sahab rather than what Bade Sahab is going to do in the film. Sometimes one actor's name would come up, sometimes another actor's name would come up. Many times, I also wondered who was playing this character."

Unlike the star-studded cast of the two-part crime saga, which includes Ranveer Singh, Ashay Khanna, R Madhavan, Arjun Rampal and Sanjay, Iqbal may not be a recognised face. But the actor has been part of several acclaimed projects such as OTT shows 'Maharani', 'Aranyak', 'The Hunt: The Rajiv Gandhi Assassination Case' and movies 'Bhakshak' and 'Haq'.

Iqbal said that following the character's reveal, audience curiosity shifted towards how Ibrahim looks and sounds now, rather than the person behind the don's persona.

"The way everything was created, the world of that character, when people saw it, they forgot about which actor it was. They started focusing on the character itself. And that is the beauty that when a character is properly brought to life on screen, people appreciate the art more, rather than glorifying the personality of the actor. They start liking



THE REVELATION CAME AS A SURPRISE EVEN TO THE ACTOR HIMSELF

the character. The appreciation I received for my acting talent became more important."

'Dhurandhar: The Revenge' features Singh as Jaskirat Singh Rang, a young man who transforms into covert operative Hamza Ali Mazari operating deep inside Pakistan. The sequel charts Mazari's rise in the Karachi underworld while tracing the origins of the man behind the cover.

Indian filmmakers have long been fascinated by Ibrahim, each offering their own take on the don on screen. One of the most portrayed figures in Hindi cinema, Ibrahim has been depicted both directly and through inspired

characters across films such as Ram Gopal Varma's 'Company', Anurag Kashyap's 'Black Friday', where Vijay Maurya portrayed him by name. Hashmi also played the don in 'Once Upon a Time in Mumbai', while late cinema star Rishi Kapoor portrayed him in Nikkhil Advani's 'D-Day'.

Iqbal said he deliberately kept himself from thinking about other portrayals of the underworld don. "I was worried that I might get trapped in that circle, that I have to portray the character's image... But then I forgot that this is the name of a character who has a reference in front of us."

And all the actors who have portrayed him, because then I wouldn't have been able to play this role. I was thinking that these are the given circumstances and these are the dialogues. These are his co-actors with whom he is talking and these are his problems. And what is his demand?

What does he want? Focusing on all these things, I made the character. I didn't imitate anyone."

The physical transformation for the character was equally demanding, the actor said, while revealing that the prosthetic ageing makeup took between eight and ten hours to complete each day on set. "On the first day, I thought it would be done in two or three hours, no big deal. But it took me five hours to complete it. And eventually, it took eight to nine hours. Sometimes 10 hours," he said.

"It doesn't look like makeup. It looks like a person. And that's why it's so difficult to do it - portraying that age, portraying his illness, portraying his challenges on screen," he added.

Iqbal was effusive in his praise for director Dhar, calling him a 'fantastic director' who created the right conditions for performance. "He will provide you with that ultimate atmosphere on the set - peace and quietness - where you can actually feel comfortable and do what you actually want to do," he said.

Iqbal credited Dhar and casting director Mukesh Chhabra for ensuring every actor, regardless of stature, received their due screen presence. "In Indian cinema, we have this tendency that a veteran or a star gets more screen time while an important but lesser-known character gets minimal presence. But here Aditya sir stuck to his characters, to his storyline - what is good for the scene, what is good for the film," he said.

"Each and every actor is being noticed and appreciated. That's the beauty of this 'Dhurandhar' film," Iqbal added.

AGENCIES

RYAN COOGLER ON 'BLACK PANTHER'

'I was convinced that the movie wasn't going to work'



Filmmaker Ryan Coogler said he learnt to stay more present in the moment from the film's late star Chadwick Boseman

If there is anything that 'Sinners' director Ryan Coogler has learned from his 2018 blockbuster superhero drama 'Black Panther' and its late star Chadwick Boseman, it's to stay more present in the moment.

Coogler's 'Sinners' became the most nominated film in Oscar history with 16 nods for the 2026 edition and also won many Oscar awards. The record was earlier shared by 'All About Eve' (1950), 'Titanic' (1997) and 'La La Land' (2016) with 14 nominations each.

In an interview with 'The Hollywood Reporter', Coogler spoke about the lessons he learned from Boseman, the 'Black Panther' star who passed away in 2020 after a secret four-year battle with cancer. He was 43.

"Engaging with him on an artistic level, conversations that will forever just be between him and me - I was about 30 years old, stressed, completely out of my mind and sleep-deprived, convinced that the movie wasn't going to work. I robbed myself of truly enjoying that privilege - even of sitting there and enjoying the countless Chadwick Boseman takes, because he didn't have a bad take. So, when he passed, I was like, 'Oh my God, how much stuff have I not allowed myself to enjoy because I was in my own head - feeling like I was unworthy?'" Coogler said.

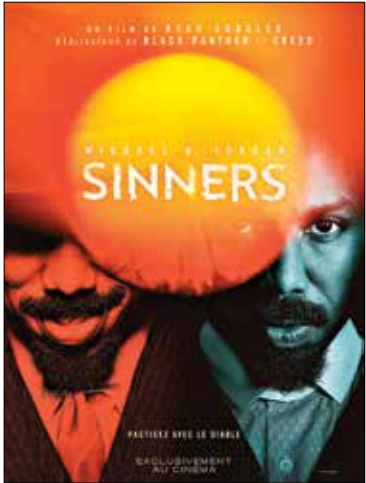
He added, "I'm going to take the lessons from Chad for the rest of my life, bro. That includes all of this. I have to see the good in things, see the value in things and not let impostor syndrome or guilt or negativity rob me of moments with my cast, who I love - or with folks who want to say, 'Hey, good job!'"

Coogler was in his mid-20s when he impressed Hollywood with his directorial debut 'Fruitvale Station', which revolved around the real-life events leading up to the 2009 death of 22-year-old Oscar Grant in a police shooting. His second project was 'Creed', a spin-off to Sylvester Stallone's 'Rocky' franchise.

'Black Panther', which amassed USD 1.35 billion worldwide, was praised for the way it honoured the black culture and history through the story of a king who rules a technologically advanced African country, hidden from the world.

Coogler was deep into making the sequel when the pandemic hit and they all learned about Boseman's death. The filmmaker had to rewrite the story in a way that honoured Boseman's legacy but continued the story without him.

'Wakanda Forever', which initially seemed like an easy continuation of the world shown in 'Black Panther', had to be reframed completely with Bose-



'Sinners', his first movie since his debut to have no IP connection, was inspired by Coogler's great-uncle James Edmonson, who died in 2015

man's T'Challa dying at the beginning of the film.

"I would look around to people who had been making movies as long as I had been alive, bro, sometimes longer and they would say: 'I've never seen anything like this,'" Coogler said about the time.

He added, "We had to work from the place of being brokenhearted or else it wouldn't have got done. Chad and I were getting closer, so it was like a wound to the heart. It was like somebody had taken the sun away and we were all these planets floating."

The filmmaker looks back at the time with sadness and also pride. "I learned that I was more resilient than I give myself credit for - I'll say that was the biggest thing... And that movie gets watched at home so much more than the other 'Panther' did. I think about that: People may be watching when they want to feel something specific."

'Sinners', his first movie since his debut to have no IP connection, was inspired by Coogler's great-uncle James Edmonson, who died in 2015. A genre-bending story that combines Black history, Blues music, Jim Crow South, cultural appropriation and vampires, 'Sinners' released last year.

PTI



SENSE AND SENSIBILITY

PLAYING ON...

AUTHOR



BY SUPRIYA NEWAR

There is a scene in the film 'Titanic' that has stayed with me long after the love story faded and the spectacle of the sinking ship dimmed

There is a scene in the film 'Titanic' that has stayed with me long after the love story faded and the spectacle of the sinking ship dimmed. As the great vessel begins to tilt and panic spreads, as lifeboats are lowered and people scramble for survival, four musicians walk up to the deck and begin to play. Not as a protest. Not as performance. Simply because it is what they can offer; it is what they know how to do. In the middle of a catastrophe, they choose music.

I have been thinking about those musicians and that visual.

For the past fortnight, it has been rather hard to think of much else besides the news. War headlines have colonised prime time television (the new 'Bridgerton' season must wait), morning papers and the relentless scroll of the phone screen. The images are not easy - drones cutting through skies like something from a dystopian film, busy airports shut and related implications that the mind is trying to process or failing to.

And yet, life continues in the smaller windows between the headlines. The 'WhatsApp' groups march on, with horror and the humour sitting cheek to jowl. Cylinder jokes arrive between footage of destruction. Memes about the stock market share space with appeals for humanitarian aid. Someone ritually forwards a sunrise photograph with an



inspirational quote about hope.

Watching closely, one also notices the range of coping dialects being spoken all around. Some people go quiet and philosophical, suddenly aware of how small a dot they are in this vast, indifferent universe and finding, oddly, a kind of humility and peace in that smallness. Others swing to the opposite end entirely - YOLO - you only live once, they declare and vehemently play the game. If the world is this fragile and arbitrary, why not take the leap - quit the job, book the trip, get the tattoo or file for separation! Then there are the pragmatists, coolly advising that a bloodbath is, historically, an excellent time to enter the stock market. Mutual funds, they remind you, are subject to market risk. Clearly, quite apparently, so is everything else.

The truth is, there is no correct way to hold a crisis that isn't yours and yet has somehow landed on your plate - this one quite literally as induction stoves replace LPG flames. Some will cope through laughter, some with solidarity; some will

follow every development obsessively, whilst others will switch off entirely, knowing that the headlines will continue with or without their anxiety as witnesses.

None of these responses is entirely wrong. None is entirely right either. They are simply the different ways we ordinary folks are trying to make some sense of it all and come out at the other end, less hurt, less hollowed out and still standing. Each path is valid. Each is, in its own way, a person playing their instrument on the deck.

What perhaps matters more than which path we choose is what we carry with us along the way. In times like these, when cynicism is never more than a headline away, when outrage is abundant and hope feels almost naive, it becomes quietly important to hold onto two small, unglamorous things: kindness and the ability to simply take the next step. For ourselves as much as for the people next to us. Not grand gestures - simply the willingness to offer a smile if not a solution, a moment of warmth if not an answer.

The musicians on the 'Titanic' couldn't stop the ship from sinking. But they played anyway. It's what they could do. It's what made their sonata unforgettable.

Supriya Newar is a multi-lingual writer and poet from Calcutta. Besides being a music aficionado, she is also an avid traveller. She may be reached at connect@supriyanewar.com